DAILY TROJAN MAGAZINE
THE SUMMER EDITION
ISSUE 06 | JUNE 2024

DT mag
EST. 2023

# NEIGHBORHOOD ACADEMIC INITIATIVE FALLS SHORT

BY THE *DAILY TROJAN* SPRING 2024 EDITORIAL BOARD

## USC UPS ITS PROFIT MARGINS

BY REO

## PLAYING WITH PRIDE

BY JENNIFER NEHRER

## FOLT'S FIVE YEARS

BY JONATHAN PARK

## SUMMER *2024* EDITORS

*Editor-in-Chief*
**KIMBERLY AGUIRRE**

*Managing Editors*
**STEFANO FENDRICH**
**ALIA YEE NOLL**
**NATHAN ELIAS**

*Chief Copy Editor*
**HALO LYMAN**

*Art & Design Director*
**VIVIENNE TRAN**

*Photo Editor*
**ISABELLA VILLANUEVA**

*Magazine Editor*
**SASHA RYU**

# TABLE OF CONTENTS

*CAMPUS*

**THE QUEST TO FIND USC'S SMALLEST MAJOR, 6**

BY SAMMY BOVITZ

**USC UPS ITS PROFIT MARGINS, 18**

BY REO

**FOLT'S FIVE YEARS, 28**

BY JONATHAN PARK

**ARMENIAN HISTORY HONTH AT USC — 100 YEARS IN THE MAKING, 44**

BY JENNIFER NEHRER

*COVER STORY*

**NEIGHBORHOOD ACADEMIC INITIATIVE FALLS SHORT, 10**

BY THE *DAILY TROJAN* SPRING 2024 EDITORIAL BOARD

*COMMUNITY*

**PLAYING WITH PRIDE, 36**

BY JENNIFER NEHRER

*SUMMER FRAME*

**HOMETOWNS, 52**

BY THE DAILY TROJAN PHOTOGRAPHY TEAM

*NATURE*

**LA MAY BE THE NEW CABO; WE CAN'T LET THAT HAPPEN, 24**

BY DANIEL PONS

*LETTERS TO THE EDITOR*

**OUR QUEER LEADERS CANNOT BE COLLATERAL, 32**

BY THE STUDENT COMMUNITY OF THE LGBTQ+ STUDENT CENTER AND JUSTICE EQUITY DIVERSITY INCLUSION AT USC

*CAMPUS*

**AN OPEN LETTER TO "THE BABY-SITTERS CLUB," 56**

BY RACHEL KOZIK

COVER ART: GRAYSON SEIBERT / DAILY TROJAN. OPENING SPREAD: ZONGYI WANG / DAILY TROJAN

# *from the editor*

For the past seven years, student journalism has been at the center of my life. I'm 21 years old, about to enter my senior year of college, and I still can't decide whether or not that's a good thing.

When I started writing in high school, every interview and every headline felt exhilarating, but by the time I came to USC, I was terrified that I'd spend another four years sitting in a newsroom. I've never wanted to be a professional journalist — I still don't. But despite my best efforts, I can never seem to escape how much I love doing this job.

Journalism is a pillar of our democracy and one of my life's greatest passions, but I do not believe that it is a noble profession. I think, if anything, journalists are important in the same way that politicians are important — every day, we provide a highly consequential public service, but it would be ridiculous to call ourselves heroes for doing so.

I've seen this industry bring out the worst in people — particularly in myself. I can spend a whole day without saying one nice thing, and I can wake up the next morning and do the same thing all over again. In an industry that thrives in times of controversy and conflict, it is difficult to avoid prioritizing the bad days over the good ones. It is even more difficult to avoid becoming bitter. I understand why people don't like journalists. There are a lot of things that I clearly don't like about journalists either. Still, it stings when I hear people outside of our profession write us off altogether.

My friends and I have spent so many nights in the newsroom working on a story for hours just for people to skim a few of our headlines on Instagram and tell us with all the conviction in the world that we're "everything" that's wrong with the media today. I know it's silly to take those kinds of comments to heart, but some days, they eat away at me, and my life feels impossible to escape.

The thing that made it possible for me to balance the stressful and discouraging parts of this job was the constant support I got from the other people on the paper. As much as it might seem like I hate journalists, the people I've met at the *Daily Trojan* have become some of my closest friends and my biggest role models. Every day, they make me laugh, and they inspire me to be a better person.

After my co-editors took on different positions at the end of the school year, I stayed on as the only News editor for the summer. Doing the job alone made me appreciate just how much easier things were when I could work with our old team whenever there was a problem. Of course, even without them by my side, I was never actually working alone, thanks to the constant support I had from our managing editors, **Stefano Fendrich**, **Alia Yee Noll** and **Nathan Elias**; as well as our editor-in-chief, **Kimberly Aguirre**; our chief copy editor, **Halo Lyman**; and our Art & Design director, **Vivienne Tran**.

On June 26, we sent out the last pages of my relatively short but incredibly eventful career as a News editor. I'm more than ready to move on to a new chapter, but it's bittersweet to see such a big part of my life come to a close.

Working on this magazine after living through an unimaginably chaotic news cycle in the spring has been eye-opening, to say the least. In the News section, our writers never have the opportunity to share their personal narratives. This, of course, is for good reason, but after spending years trying to separate writers from their stories, there's something so special about seeing people share their experiences and perspectives so boldly and so freely.

I invite you now to read the stories that have reintroduced me to my love for journalism — the stories that have held such a special place in my heart this whole summer.

In this issue, **Jennifer Nehrer** explores what Pride Month means to queer athletes and fans, as well as the importance of Armenian pride on campus. The student community of the LGBTQ+ Student Center and Justice Equity Diversity Inclusion at USC speaks out in a letter to the editor against queer leaders becoming collateral in the struggle between the University and pro-Palestinian protesters on campus. **Sammy Bovitz** recounts his journey searching for the smallest major at USC. **Reo** investigates how the University has upped its profit margins since the start of the coronavirus pandemic. **Jonathan Park** reflects on President Carol Folt's past five years in office. **Daniel Pons** explains the importance of ethical landscaping as climates continue to shift. The *Daily Trojan* Spring 2024 Editorial Board discusses how the Neighborhood Academic Initiative falls short in addressing systemic issues. The *Daily Trojan* photography team shares a new installment of the Summer Frame, and **Rachel Kozik** closes out the issue with a heartwarming letter to "The Baby-Sitters Club."

I hope these stories take a special place in your heart in the way they have for me.

Until next time, happy reading and happy summer!

**Sasha Ryu**
Editor, *Daily Trojan Magazine*

MIA CLAIRE CHANG / DAILY TROJAN

Shea Noland / Daily Trojan

# The quest to find USC's smallest major

*Sammy Bovitz embarks on a monthslong odyssey to unpack a seemingly simple question.*

SAMMY BOVITZ

Sometimes, the search to answer a simple question is easy — but not this time.

## THE SEARCH

My quest to find the smallest undergraduate major at the University of Southern California began back in February, with a 35-page PDF from IPEDS called "Completions 2023-24." This sprawling, headache-inducing document contains comprehensive data on every degree earned or "completed" by a USC student during the 2022-2023 school year. But when you're looking for a needle in a haystack, looking at the entire haystack is a pretty solid place to start.

This glorified spreadsheet had everything I needed — except, of course, anything I would need to make this process easier for myself. There was no way to sort by degree type or even use "command-F," the keyboard shortcut for finding key phrases in a document, meaning I would have to find each individual bachelor's degree amid a sea of doctoral and master's degrees. There was also a thorough breakdown of major students by gender and double major, which would be useful if not for the all-important row of "Total" requiring significant squinting for each painstaking entry.

But the most aggravating part of my search was enduring the system by which the majors were organized. IPEDS, the organization that provided me with "Completions 2023-24," stands for "Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System." IPEDS has created a framework known as Classification of Instructional Programs codes, which organize collegiate degrees. CIP codes are essentially a Dewey Decimal System for units of study, complete with universalized names for every undergraduate program at every college.

This means next to nothing for the general public, but for me, it meant that I had to figure out each USC major that a given CIP code corresponded to. Some of these codes had an exact equivalent, like 11.0701 — "Computer Science." But many required interpretation, like 52.1301 — "Management Science" — which turned out to be the business administration major.

After a few days of this spreadsheet from hell, I had a list of every bachelor's degree handed out by USC in the previous year — according to the lengthy PDF, 117 in total. To narrow this massive list down, I cross-checked these numbers with the USC student directory and eliminated every single major with more than 25 students listed in the directory.

But that wasn't the only thing I had to check. You see, some of these "completions" listed on the PDF were emphases within majors — for example, the chemical biology emphasis within the chemistry major — or interdisciplinary majors. Interdisciplinary majors often

"AFTER A FEW DAYS OF THIS SPREADSHEET FROM HELL, I HAD A LIST OF EVERY BACHELOR'S DEGREE HANDED OUT BY USC IN THE PREVIOUS YEAR – ACCORDING TO THE LENGTHY PDF, 117 IN TOTAL."

lack a set curriculum and can often have small departments, meaning these majors can be reconstructed by practically anyone at any time. In fact, it's technically possible that the smallest major is one with zero students as of this spring.

But I wanted to find a major that existed as a minuscule program in spite of a dedicated and large department, as well as a precise curriculum. These interdisciplinary programs, even if they may have some of the "smallest" majors, were not quite what I was looking for.

After I determined which majors were interdisciplinary or emphases within larger majors, I then set out on my directory cross-checking in earnest, eliminating any major with more than 10 students this time. After some fact-checking with the Office of Institutional Research, I found what I was looking for.

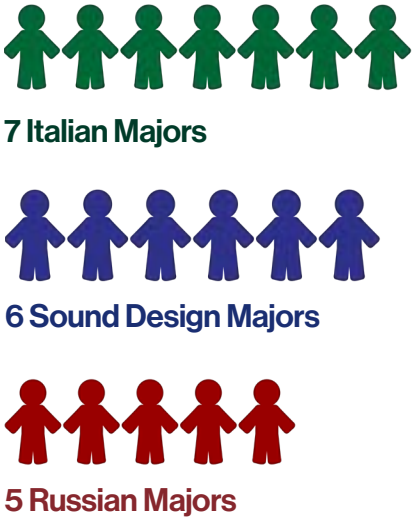
## THE ANSWER

Sometimes, a simple answer tells the whole story — again, not this time.

My monthslong quest to find USC's smallest major ended with a thud. It was April Fool's Day, and I got an email that fact-checked the numbers I had requested.

As of May 2024, the smallest major at the University of Southern California is Russian, with just five students. It's followed closely by sound design, which has six students, and Italian, which has seven.

A major is an inescapable part of one's identity at any university. I've sometimes introduced myself with my major before I've even said my name; "Hi, I'm a freshman journalism major — oh, and my name's Sammy." So, what does it mean to have a major, such an integral part of who you are, exist on the margins of your own university?




Vivienne Tran / Daily Trojan

To find out, I reached out to those who are a part of the three smallest majors at USC. While each person interviewed had plenty of thoughts on this newfound data, one reaction was conspicuously absent.

## THE COMMUNITY

"I'm not surprised," said Colleen McQuillen, an associate professor of Slavic languages and literatures.

When I asked why, McQuillen told me she believed that many students are skeptical of a foreign language major due to the rise in modern translation technology. This is something that Gian-Maria Annovi, an associate professor of Italian and comparative literature, was eager to mention.

"In general, languages tend to have a very limited number of majors today," Annovi said. "It wasn't the case in the past, but there have been a lot of changes in cultural attitudes."

These shifts in public perception around foreign language studies mean small cohorts of major students may have to take classes with the same professors over and over again. Take Sophia Meyer, a senior majoring in Italian as well as philosophy, politics and law, who has taken countless courses with … Annovi!

"It was funny when you reached out and were like, 'Oh, Professor Annovi gave me your email,'" Meyer told me. "I've taken like five classes with him … So me and him just got

super tight over the course of a few semesters. Every semester, I would just show up and be like, 'Are we ready to do this again?'"

But the story of the smallest majors at USC is not limited to just languages clawing for relevance in an increasingly STEM-dominated world. Sometimes, a major is intentionally created to be small.

"It's not a hard cap, but the goal is to have no more than eight to 10 students in the program total across four years," said Philip Allen, the director of sound design at the School of Dramatic Arts.

Allen explained that this restriction of the sound design major was made for a very simple reason: "Mainstage" productions at SDA are few and far between, and the program wants to guarantee that any major student is able to do design work on real productions as soon as possible.

That said, don't take the lack of surprise as a lack of passion for their respective fields. Meyer spoke glowingly of her experience throughout her Italian studies, smiling as she told me about planning to meet with one of her professors for a farewell dinner. Annovi couldn't help but rave about the importance of studying a foreign language, apologizing for his length of speech but not for his enthusiasm. McQuillen even went out of her way to thank me for the opportunity to talk about her program. In a way, I believe I've found the only thing rarer than the Russian major — a faculty member thanking a student journalist for writing a story about them.

Just because these majors are small doesn't mean they are weak. In fact, their smaller size bequeaths strengths that those in larger programs could only dream of.

"JUST BECAUSE THESE MAJORS ARE SMALL DOESN'T MEAN THEY ARE WEAK. IN FACT, THEIR SMALLER SIZE BEQUEATHS STRENGTHS THAT THOSE IN LARGER PROGRAMS COULD ONLY DREAM OF."

The entire sound design program, for example, meets once a week to share production experiences and pass on additional knowledge, as Noel Nichols, an assistant professor of theatre practice in sound design, told me. This is an inconceivable privilege for practically any other major.

Meyer told me that she met her best friend, a fellow Italian major, through the program. In the years that followed, she was guaranteed a spot right next to that friend every time she came to class.

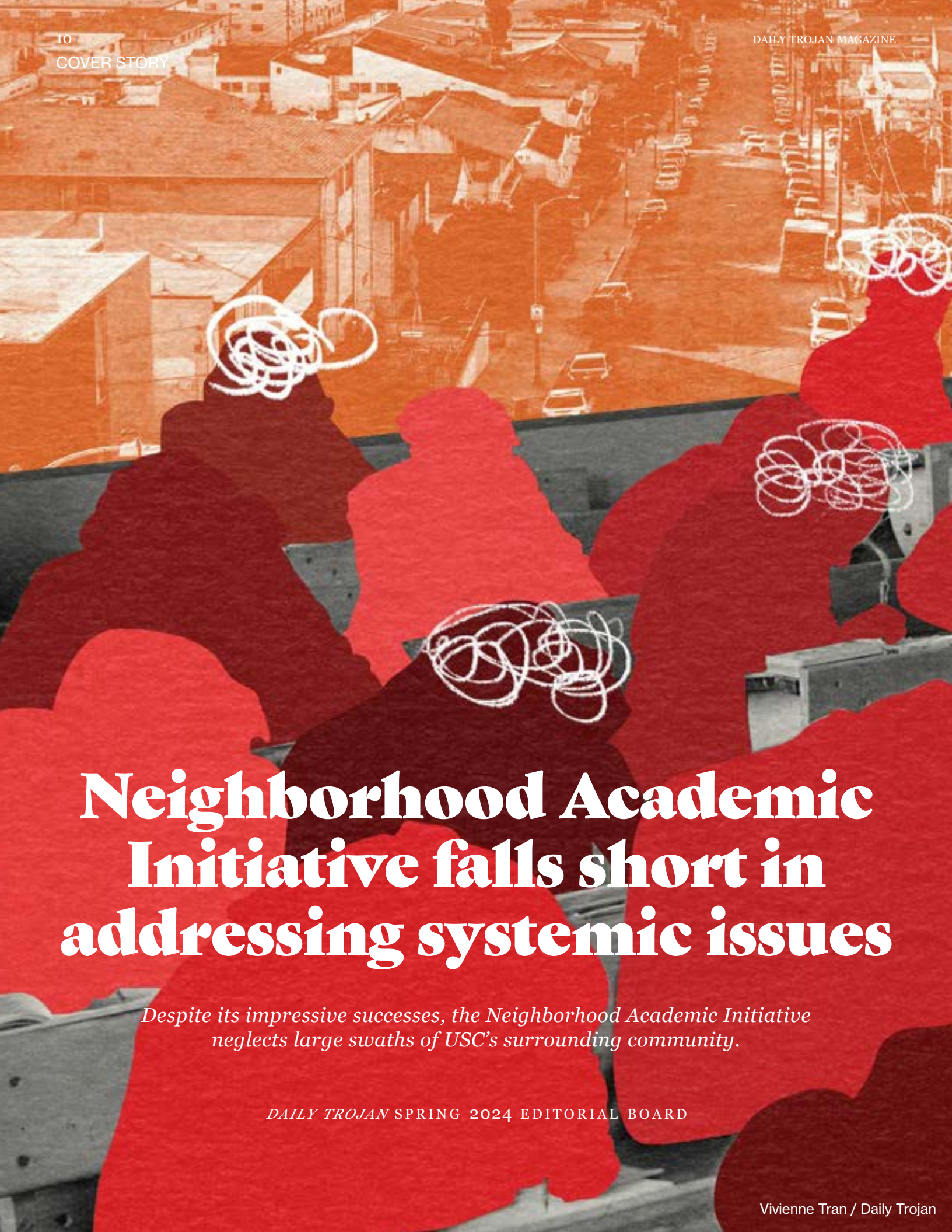
McQuillen, for her part, praised her department's condemnation of and response to Russia's war in Ukraine. Despite being the smallest major at USC, their sweeping reaction to the war — from student-run fundraisers to micro-seminars to special events — is one fit for a much larger program.

"We're doing our best to try to use it as an opportunity to educate people about this part of the world," McQuillen told me.

Russian, sound design and Italian may be the smallest majors at USC — but what these majors lack in quantity of students is more than made up for by, quite simply, everything else about them. Join one if you'd like, but you don't need to worry about them.

They're doing just fine.

*Sammy Bovitz was an assistant Arts & Entertainment editor in Spring 2024. He is a rising sophomore majoring in journalism.*



# Neighborhood Academic Initiative falls short in addressing systemic issues

*Despite its impressive successes, the Neighborhood Academic Initiative neglects large swaths of USC's surrounding community.*

*DAILY TROJAN* SPRING 2024 EDITORIAL BOARD

Vivienne Tran / Daily Trojan

"I've always wanted to go to USC since I was young," said Destiny Echeverria, a junior majoring in business administration who graduated from USC's McMorrow Neighborhood Academic Initiative in 2021. "Thanks to [the Neighborhood Academic Initiative], I got into USC, and now I'm at USC."

From complaints about gentrification to volunteer outreach programs like Friends and Neighbors Day, Trojans often scrutinize how USC impacts its surrounding community. Graduates from arguably one of the most successful of USC's community programs have some of the most informed criticisms of all.

NAI is an outreach program providing support for about 1,000 low-income sixth to 12th grade students each year. The program has incredible success rates, with a 100% high school graduation rate and a 99% college graduation rate. But for its many attributes, the program also fails to address systemic issues within the community and the Los Angeles Unified School District, as well as putting immense pressure on students as young as fifth grade.

The program also socially isolates these students from their fellow classmates, often encouraging a sense of assimilation into the elitist culture of USC. It is extremely rigorous, involving a huge six-year commitment for students and their parents, one that asks these students to go above and beyond their peers for support that should be accessible to all children.

Despite its flaws, NAI uniquely provides students with an invaluable opportunity, even offering full-tuition scholarships to any of its students who get into USC. NAI reports that 43% of its students have attended USC since its first graduating class in 1997.

This year, NAI had a record 95 scholars graduating from the program who plan to attend college and a record 65 admitted to USC, according to a statement from the University.

**This year, NAI had a record *95 graduating scholars who plan to attend college* and a record *65 admitted to USC.***

Vivienne Tran / Daily Trojan

With the impact NAI has, we must look deeper to understand how USC can improve this program and create lasting, sustainable change in our community. After speaking with several current and former NAI scholars, we hope to give insight into the shortcomings of the program's student experience.

## HOW NAI WORKS

NAI is, at its core, a college preparatory program. It pulls students from neighborhoods near USC, mainly in South Central and East L.A., who are assessed and interviewed for the program in fifth grade. Admitted students then participate in a "demanding regimen" of early morning and weekend classes on the USC campus, according to the program's website.

"USC is deeply committed to expanding access for students of all backgrounds to attend a top-tier university," the University wrote in a statement to the Daily Trojan. "This cornerstone priority includes the groundbreaking program … NAI is one of the nation's most comprehensive college access and success programs."

These students must apply to the program at the ages of 10 or 11 by obtaining a Student Criteria Sheet completed by one of their teachers. They are then interviewed for the program, a practice that is repeated in 8th grade when students are reevaluated to continue the program in high school.

If students are admitted to the program, they and their parents must agree to "attend all Saturday Academy sessions for seven years and parents must agree to attend the family development institute on Saturdays," according to NAI's website.

NAI's commitment to helping parents as well as students is an admirable one, but one that is not feasible for all parents. However, NAI does offer the opportunity for parents who have work or other obligations to send an advocate in their place to these events.

Still, asking parents to commit to "meet[ing] on the University Park campus for three hours on Saturday mornings about 12 to 16 times a year" can be a large burden for these low-income families, who may not have the support of an advocate to fill in for them.

An agreement made by a fifth grader and their guardians — one that is binding for seven years — seems like an immense decision for a child, and even their parents, to make when they have no idea what the next seven years will hold.

Students must also reapply for NAI in eighth grade, when the program typically cuts students who don't meet the minimum GPA requirement. At a time when NAI could offer further support for students who did make that commitment but are struggling, the program instead allows them to slip through the cracks.

## ACADEMIC DEMAND & SHORTCOMINGS

Students report facing difficult decisions between participating in sports and other extracurriculars that could take away their time, and therefore eligibility, for NAI. Others say they felt like they were walking on eggshells, afraid to get in any trouble or slip up in a way that would result in removal from NAI.

In exchange for the onerous requirements, NAI offers unmatched support for these students and their families, including a counselor in their junior year to guide them through college applications and financial aid. Even after graduation from NAI, students who attend USC have support on campus, and students who attend other colleges receive visits from NAI staff in their freshman year to ensure that their hard work results in a degree.

Students also have access to scholarships, internship opportunities and access to the NAI Alumni Network. This level of commitment is admirable and a testament to the positive intent and impact of the program — although students said they see the program as an investment into getting students to USC, rather than purely a way to give back to the community.

> "AN AGREEMENT MADE BY A FIFTH GRADER AND THEIR GUARDIANS — ONE THAT IS BINDING FOR SEVEN YEARS — SEEMS LIKE AN IMMENSE DECISION FOR A CHILD, AND EVEN THEIR PARENTS."

By drilling acceptance into USC as its main end goal, the program has established a culture that clearly differentiates academic expectations between NAI and non-NAI students.

Every single morning at Saturday Academy, NAI students have to recite a Scholars' Code of Ethics — including an affirmation that they will work towards receiving a scholarship from USC, according to Echeverria, who also works as an NAI tutor and office assistant.

"NAI's Saturday Academy gives students the rigorous academic immersion they need to compete on a national level by providing instruction in English, math and college preparation," the University wrote in its statement.

However, Echeverria said that because matriculation into USC is presented as the primary purpose of NAI it has deepened the divide for students not participating in the program. The academic goals of non-NAI students are consequently undermined or glossed over.

Daniel Rios attended Foshay Learning Center, a South Central school that participates in NAI and is USC's top feeder school. Rios was initially accepted into NAI in elementary school but was later taken out of the program after his first year when his grades fell short. He said that he attempted to reenter NAI in middle school, but was unsuccessful.

"They didn't give me the resources to better my grade," Rios said. "I didn't really feel supported in wanting to come into the program."

Rios also said he struggled with the college application process and faced a more difficult transition from high school to college.

"I felt very left out in terms of seeking college scholarships or talking to people who can help me with aid," Rios said. "[NAI students] had specific NAI counselors that knew the ins and outs of the college system."

In NAI's mission to prepare a small group of students for a "top-tier" college education, they leave out a larger group who would also benefit from higher education. Even if they aren't as prestigious as USC, helping a wider audience of students get into more affordable community colleges would have an invaluable impact.

## SOCIAL ISOLATION & PROGRAM CULTURE

The academic and social separation between NAI students and non-NAI students is apparent in their high schools. Along with the increased time and rigor of the program, the required curriculum for NAI scholars is vastly different from thaWt of students not in the program. Consequently, these students rarely share classes making it difficult for them to collaborate.

Echeverria said she had to "fight" to have classes with her friends while also taking higher-level classes. On the flip side, Echeverria said NAI students had an unspoken expectation to be role models for others.

"I felt like we had to make ourselves an example to [non-NAI students] that, you know, 'We're serious about it. You should step it up too,'" Echeverria said. "There was a silent superficiality."

Further, the program leaves behind non-NAI students, providing little to no support for the majority of students in local schools. By focusing on a select few who the program deems worthy of their time and effort, resources are redirected away from the larger student body that could benefit from them.

"There was some sort of isolation," Rios said about his time after being removed from the program. "Because it was really separate, most of the resources went towards [NAI], and I don't think students were able to get proper support because of that."

The isolating culture of the NAI program does not stop once its alumni enter USC as college students. NAI students take countless classes on USC's campuses, but many are unprepared for the elitist culture that permeates USC as a private, prestigious institution.

The annual NAI Gala and Awards Ceremony perfectly exemplifies this forced assimilation. The gala celebrates the graduating class of NAI students — though it seems to celebrate the donors of NAI more than anything else.

Along with holding a workshop for students to learn how to network and interact with donors, an auction-style event is held at the gala for donors to give money to the program. Some USC students who were in NAI said it was "awkward" to watch, since they and their families couldn't afford to contribute a donation.

Kiana Amaya, a sophomore majoring in urban planning, graduated from NAI in 2022. She described how the gala announces the scholarships by having the NAI students stand up while presenting the amount of money they were rewarded.

"It kind of felt like we were being sold," Amaya said. "I felt like I had to play up an act so USC could look better. It was really weird."

Beginning from the separation of students in elementary school, social isolation extends to USC, where many NAI alumni said they felt impostor syndrome.

"Reality just hit me," Echeverria said, referring to her first year at USC. "Seeing the reality of different socioeconomic levels and everything compared to me and these other students, it did hit my self-esteem for a bit."

"NAI STUDENTS TAKE COUNTLESS CLASSES ON USC'S CAMPUSES, BUT MANY ARE UNPREPARED FOR THE ELITIST CULTURE THAT PERMEATES USC AS A PRIVATE, PRESTIGIOUS INSTITUTION."

Isabella Villanueva / Daily Trojan File Photo

## SYSTEMIC ISSUES WITH LAUSD

LAUSD is the second-largest public school district in the nation. But the way schools receive their funding disproportionately harms low-income neighborhoods, in comparison to higher-income neighborhoods. Ultimately, the area in which a school is located will impact students' quality of education.

## IT BEGINS WITH PROPERTY TAXES

L.A. public schools in neighborhoods with high median incomes, where property taxes are on average higher, will receive higher funding. This impacts educational resources, from having a range of classes to providing advanced courses in preparation for testing and higher education.

California Proposition 13, passed in 1978, is behind converting market-valued property into an income value-based system. The proposition cut and capped property taxes and prevented local counties from raising money for schools. Students in low-income neighborhoods have found difficulty in excelling in courses, and test scores are low on average in low-income areas.

This becomes apparent through NAI feeder schools sitting in low-income neighborhoods. The program has successfully provided students with college preparatory assistance; however, given the limited resources these schools have, even NAI students have a limited range of rigorous courses.

Amaya said the limited courses can impact students' transition from high school to college.

"The AP [Calculus] teacher — I think he did a good job of explaining, but, he gave us a decision at the beginning of the year if you want to pass the AP exam or if you actually want to understand Calc," Amaya said. "We had no other AP system as well, so then I actually never took biology."

Quetzalli Vergara, a senior majoring in environmental studies, graduated from Foshay Learning Center as an NAI scholar. She also mentioned the lack of resources within her school.

"We didn't have a lot of AP classes," Vergara said. "I remember being an Associated Student Body student and being like 'oh, hey, you guys have to go pick up these boxes of paper USC dropped off' because we were running low on paper, the district hadn't sent us paper and USC was so gracious enough to donate to us.'"

With limited funding, the course range for students was not enough to prepare them for their specific studies. With the few AP courses Amaya mentioned, teachers would offer students the opportunity to pass the exam or learn the material. Students often chose to understand the material because it was beneficial for them to go at a slower pace to make up for the lack of mathematical preparation from prior classes.

"To be fair, [our AP Calculus teacher] had to teach us a lot of the basics," Amaya said. "So it was a lot of back to basics."

Science, technology, engineering and mathematics majors who graduated from Foshay Learning Center have found themselves having a very difficult transition from high school to college. Students had access to minimal STEM classes, and Amaya mentioned how she saw her friend, a former NAI and Foshay graduate, struggle with his civil engineering classes.

"If someone who has prep is struggling, imagine how much worse it is for someone who had nodid not have exposure to that field," Amaya said. "We like [the program], it's not to say the motivation is not there, but it definitely is way harder for us to kind of catch up and adapt to that environment."

Given LAUSD's large student population, these school districts in low-income areas need fair funding, so programs like NAI can push their students in various courses. NAI fights this issue — albeit only for a few select students — but it is a matter of LAUSD adjusting their funding guidelines and the California state legislature to make the change for fair educational funding.

However, NAI could help with this by investing in the success of all students of the school and not only selected students. Currently, NAI is making efforts to expand access to the program in other parts of L.A. and deepen connections to Crenshaw.

"In September 2023, NAI opened a new dedicated Eastside flagship classroom space. This state-of-the-art facility serves 400 scholars and is growing," the University wrote. "In South Los Angeles, NAl is leading a two-year project to expand to the Crenshaw corridor to enroll more African American students."

## REPARATIONS AND OVERALL IMPACT

NAI has served as a stepping stone for the University's collaboration with the South Central community. The area has long been impacted by the rapid gentrification caused by the expansion of student housing. Given the community's low-income demographic, they cannot afford the effects of gentrification. Through the demolition of community housing and the former University Village, USC's gentrification has been prevalent in the surrounding area.

NAI has served predominantly first-generation students. The University's commitment to NAI is a path in the right direction; however, the University must recognize its harm to the local community.

Amaya also mentioned the change from community housing to student housing.

"What we noticed [is that] all the residential housing has become Tripalink," Amaya said.

The changes caused by the expansion of student housing are visible. Ultimately, they have left small businesses and local residents negatively impacted by the development.

"There's so many more community organizations and collectives that embody what South Central is. It is community, it is livelihood," Amaya said. "NAI is an academic program to get us into USC, it is not to say it is not valuable, but I don't think that is where your knowledge about South Central should be."

The University's collaboration with the community should not end with its interactions with students but rather expand to community needs. Examples such as legal workshops for tenants in various language translations, community organizing events, small business outreach and more. As Amaya said, "NAI and its students would not be the end all, be all" of USC's outreach.

Vergara mentioned how the University could expand programs to support the entirety of South Central.

"THE UNIVERSITY'S COMMITMENT TO NAI IS A PATH IN THE RIGHT DIRECTION; HOWEVER, THE UNIVERSITY MUST RECOGNIZE ITS HARM TO THE LOCAL COMMUNITY."

"I think that could be really cool if the whole community could do that because then they can really see the impact that USC is doing," Vergara said. " I think that they have a better perspective for the community of USC's impact, not just helping a select few but also just helping everyone in the area."

NAI has served students with impactful resources; however, there is so much more USC can do to improve the lives of all South Central residents. Many NAI students come to USC from the neighboring community, and USC needs to acknowledge the homes of the students they are admitting.

"If there is a negative impact that has been seen throughout the community, with housing and poor education, stuff like that, I think it's important for us to be heard, or at least acknowledged," Rios said.

Perhaps the "Neighborhood" aspect of the initiative needs to be more heavily prioritized — not every neighbor is a potential USC student, but they all deserve reparations for how USC has affected their community.

*The* Daily Trojan *Editorial Board is a group of diverse editors and staffers from the print Opinion section. The views of the Editorial Board do not reflect the* Daily Trojan *staff as a whole.*

"NAI HAS SERVED STUDENTS WITH IMPACTFUL RESOURCES; HOWEVER, THERE IS SO MUCH MORE USC CAN DO TO IMPROVE THE LIVES OF ALL SOUTH CENTRAL RESIDENTS."

CAMPUS

Shea Noland / Daily Trojan

# USC ups its profit margins

*During the pandemic, the University saw its first profits in years. With tuition hikes galore and a growing healthcare industry, the trend seems to continue.*

REO

A few months ago, the University announced that it would be raising tuition by 4.9% for the 2024-25 school year. In response, the student body let out a collective groan.

This tuition hike marks the third of its magnitude in three years, which could be taken as a sign that USC is struggling to operate financially. Alas, it is not. In fact, the coronavirus pandemic ushered in record profits on nearly every front for the University, and those profits do not seem to be subsiding in the immediate future.

Of course, "pandemic" and "money maker" aren't usually synonymous terms — considering the economic recession caused by the former — but USC found a way to make it work.

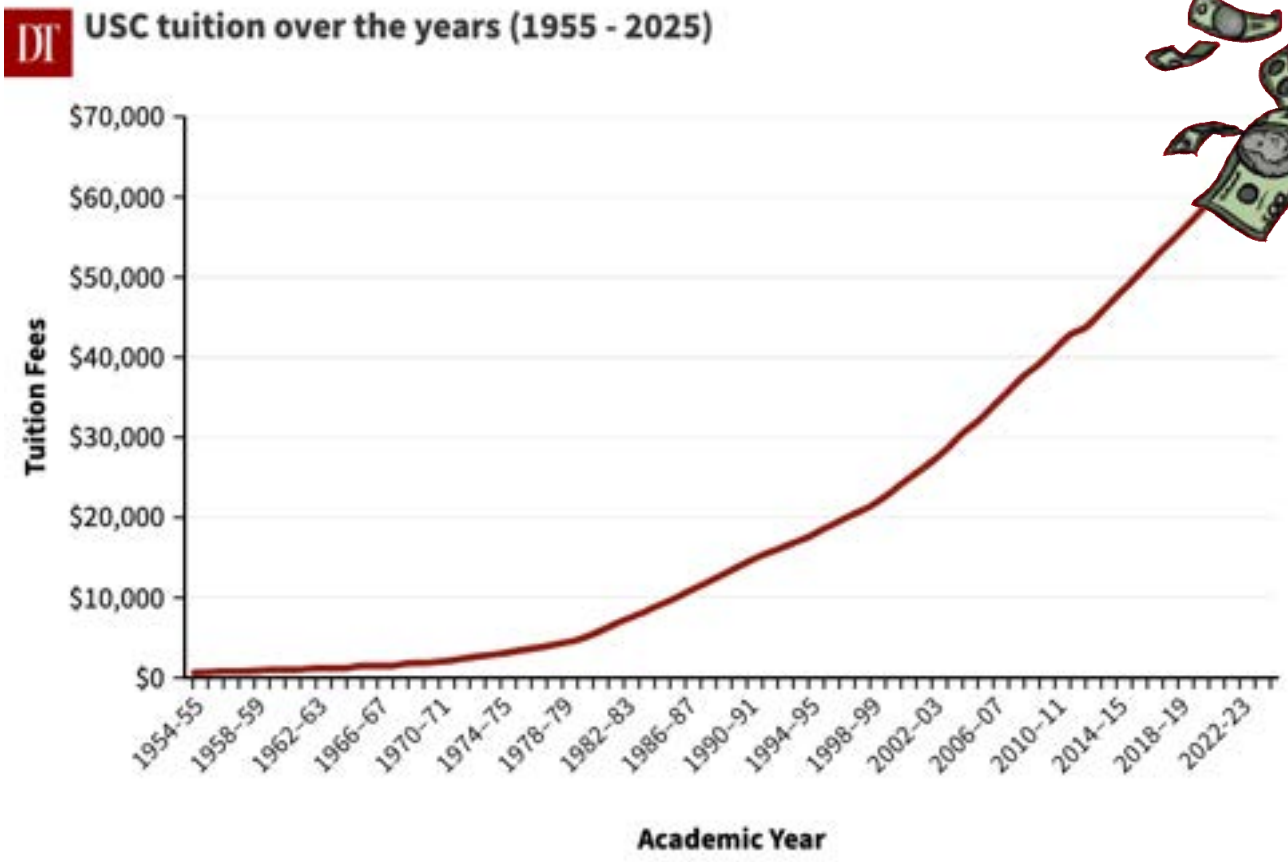
Prior to the pandemic, the University was consistently operating at a loss with its two biggest services: instruction and healthcare. From 2013 to 2019, USC spent 3% to 10% more on its instruction services than it gained from tuition, and it spent 16% to 26% more on healthcare services than it gained from them.

In comparison to other universities, this spending is no cause for concern. Emory University and The Ohio State University spent significantly more on instruction than they earned from tuition — running average losses of 47% and 32%, respectively. However, these losses were offset by these universities' health centers. In total, OSU ran a deficit of 9%, and Emory ran a deficit of 17%, compared to USC's 12%.

At USC, these losses were the status quo for many years. When the pandemic struck, USC's finances started to look a bit more lush.

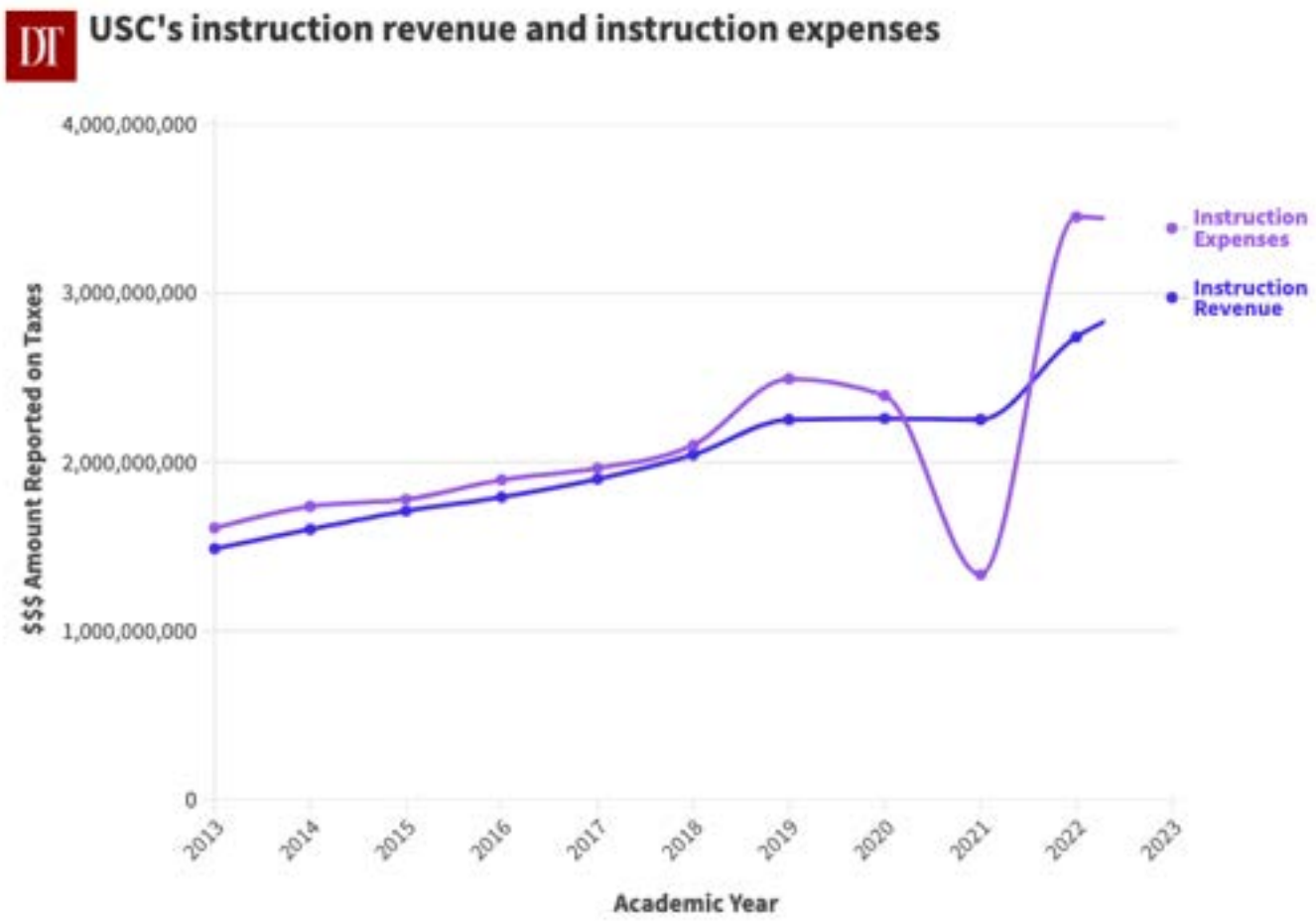
This growth in greenery started to appear in two places. First, instruction expenses began to stagnate and, eventually, fall. Second, the University's endowment skyrocketed.

During the 2019-2020 school year, despite the pandemic only




Source: USC Office of Financial Aid

Graph: Nathan Elias / Daily Trojan; Art: Shea Noland




Sasha Ryu & Reo / Daily Trojan

arriving in the latter half, instruction expenses already began to droop. USC cut expenses by almost $100 million — the next year, over $1 billion. All the while, the University continued to rake in the same amount of instruction revenue each year. Thus, the 2020-21 school year became the University's only year of profitable instruction since at least 2008, before the University's tax forms began tracking instruction revenue.

Nevertheless, donors came to the rescue to ensure that USC's newfound profits wouldn't run dry. From 2020 to 2021, the University's endowment shot up from almost $6 billion to over $8 billion.

Meanwhile, USC's healthcare services — an industry one might expect to profit from a pandemic — did not see significant changes over those two years. Expenses rose at a rate slightly faster than average, but revenue did not rise to match. Instead, healthcare services continued operating at a loss — until 2022, that is.

In the 2021-22 school year, healthcare services at USC saw a revenue leap of almost $660 million while expenses dropped by over $260 million. As tuition had before it, healthcare now became profitable.

What did all of these profits amount to? Five percent tuition hikes for three years in a row.

Following the University's profitable 2020-21 school year, instruction expenses suddenly shot up by $2 billion. The 2021-22 school year began with the lowest tuition increase in years — 2% — and ended by ushering in an age of inflation.

Still, between tuition and healthcare, USC made a profit of almost $200 million over those two years. In short, the University walked away from the pandemic with fatter pockets.

At the same time, USC laid the groundwork for a new status quo. While the $2 billion leap

in instruction expenses led to a 21% deficit in instruction services in 2021-22, tax documents obtained by the *Daily Trojan* reveal only a 12% deficit during the 2022-23 school year.

According to Erik Brink, the University's chief financial officer, "the [instruction] deficit is back to the previous range, which we expect to be the case going forward."

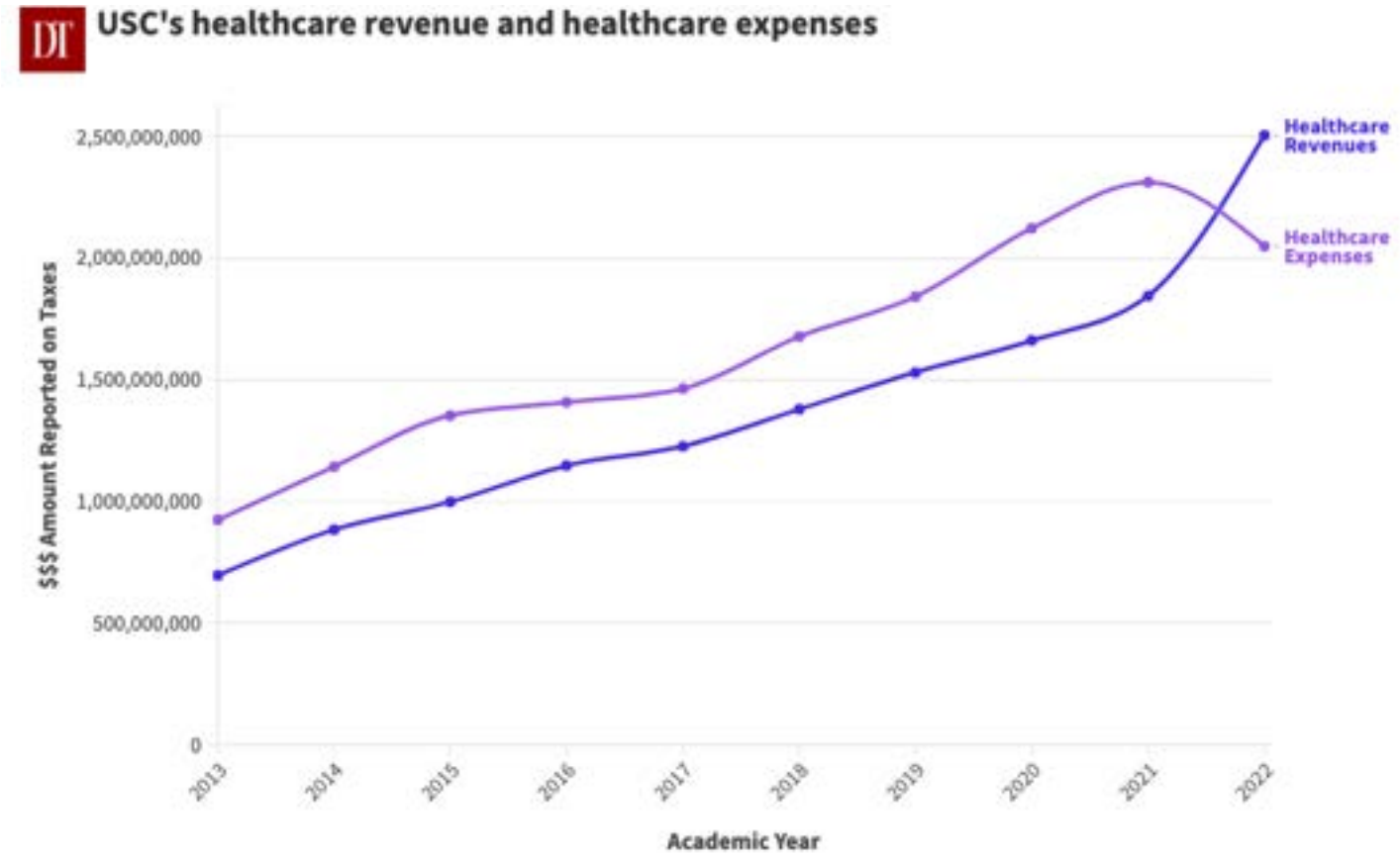
Further, USC's healthcare services split into four separate legal entities in 2021, paving the way for their first year of profitability. The four entities — USC itself, the USC Health System Corporate Entity, the Keck Medical Center of USC and the Verdugo Hills Hospital of USC — all constitute USC's health system but are legally distinct. In the process, the University began excluding pharmacy and dental services from its health system and redefining what would qualify as "health system-related activities."

In an interview with the *Daily Trojan*, Daniel Kang — an associate at Klynveld Peat Marwick Goerdeler, a company that audits university financials — said the split was to be expected.

"If there is a profitable business and a way to make the other one profitable as well, but they're dragging each other down," Kang said, "just like any successful business practice, the nature is to split the business."

USC healthcare's first profitable year points to an optimistic future. The health system that had become accustomed to deficits of 20% showed a profit of 22% in its first full year as a separate legal entity. In USC's 2022-23 tax form, the healthcare services still listed under the University itself earned a profit of $60 million. The previous year, these services accounted for one-fifth of the University's total healthcare revenue and one-fourth of the total expenses.

Of course, nothing is ever that simple when it comes to finances. The same healthcare services that are raking in profits for the University are also losing financier trust.




Sasha Ryu & Reo / Daily Trojan

In March, Moody's Ratings — one of the Big Three credit rating agencies — devalued USC's bonds because of its increasing reliance on healthcare revenue streams.

"[The downgrade] reflects a challenging operating environment for healthcare that will continue to weigh on health system and overall university margins," Moody's wrote.

As Robert Dekle, a professor of economics, puts it, this could have negative impacts on the entire University.

"If they're downgrading Universitywide bonds, then that means the interest rates are higher for borrowing, and that raises the costs," Dekle said. "That means that more tuition revenue — for example, as a simple case — has to go cover that."

Kang said the ever-present need for healthcare, even during recessions, incentivizes universities to continue investment in the sector.

"We can live without Tesla, but it might be a little bit hard to live without our doctors," Kang said.

He also expressed that university research, including research in the medical field, tends to be forward-looking.

"Universities as a whole ... are one of the few institutions left on Earth that are focused on the future," Kang said. "Quantum computing, space economy — all of these things are generally researched [by] either the government or universities first."

Kang said the devaluation was not as extreme as some other devaluations that happened last fall.

"IF THEY'RE DOWNGRADING UNIVERSITYWIDE BONDS, THEN THAT MEANS THE INTEREST RATES ARE HIGHER FOR BORROWING, AND THAT RAISES THE COSTS. THAT MEANS THAT MORE TUITION REVENUE – FOR EXAMPLE, AS A SIMPLE CASE –HAS TO GO COVER THAT."

...

**ROBERT DEKLE**

*Professor of economics*

"Overall, [USC is] still doing better than 99% of the colleges out there," Kang said.

In 2023, over 46 health systems were also devalued, some dropping close to the lowest bond rating possible.

In spite of the devaluation, Brink maintained that USC would continue to enhance its healthcare sector.

"One of USC's many priorities is to help transform the future of health. It is our goal to keep more people well across all facets of life," Brink wrote in a statement to the *Daily Trojan*. "The intentional investments being made today are expected to benefit USC over time, both financially and reputationally."

While it is common for universities nationwide to pursue these potential gains by way of their healthcare systems, an article by Bloomberg covering the devaluations pointed out that the same expenditures that seek to boost a university's profits can also bring them down.

"The medical complexes that burnish universities' reputations and bring in significant revenue are also becoming a drag on financial performance," the article reads.

Although, it would seem that the University is tending away from debt altogether. Higher profits and a strengthened endowment lead to more cash available to pass around, meaning deficits are more easily paid off.

Before that happens, though, student tuition will bolster that profit and provide the University with a cozy cushion to boot.

*Reo was a managing editor in Spring 2024. He is a rising junior majoring in journalism.*

PAGE THREE
Beach Rules Given

# SUMMER NEWS

PAGE FOUR
Young Talks Philosophy

No. 7 | Los Angeles, Calif. | Monday, July 13, 1953

HOLLYWOOD BOWL'S STARLIGHT GIRL of 1953 who will reign as hostess of College Night in the Bowl on July 16 poses prettily with her two aides, Starlight Girl, center, is Peggy Constanza of Hollywood, representing Los Angeles City College. Her two aides are Mary Medlock of Downey, representing Los Angeles State College on left and Myrna Schulman of Long Beach, representing Long Beach State College, on right. Girls were selected from 11 representatives of colleges and universities in the Southland and were judged on basis of interest in music and scholastic standing.

## Bowl College Night Thurs.

### Hollywood Symphony Series Opens 32nd Year Tomorrow Night

Hundreds of Trojans are expected to be among the students from 19 colleges and universities who are expected to take advantage of the first "College Night" in the 32-year history of the Hollywood Bowl Thursday night.

The annual "Symphonies Under the Stars" series will start tomorrow night with Bruno Walter conducting the L. A. Philharmonic orchestra. The second in the series, Tuesday, has been set aside for college students and will feature Isaac Solomon as guest conductor and Isaac Stern as violin soloist.

Students may purchase tickets for 50 cents by phoning the Hollywood Bowl office at HO 9[illegible] or at the Student Union ticket office on campus.

The Bowl association has announced that more parking facilities are available this season at the Bowl. Special buses direct to the Bowl are also available. A special area has been set aside for buses to pick up passengers after the symphony.

The Traffic department has urged Bowl patrons to park south of Hollywood Blvd. and use buses or taxicab to the Bowl.

A special feature of "College Night" will be the presentation of "The Starlight Girl" and her two attendants. Chosen from over 19 entries from southland universities and colleges, Peggy Constanza of LACC will welcome the students. Her two attendants are Mary Medlock of L.A. State and Myrna Shiffman of Long Beach State.

## Mayer Slates Lecture About U.S. Teachers

The changing function of the teacher from Puritan times to the present will be discussed in a lecture tomorrow by Dr. Frederick Mayer, visiting professor of philosophy and religion from the University of Rotterdam.

"The lecture, "The Teacher in America," will be given at 1:15 in 119 FH.

Wednesday, Dr. Mayer will hold a panel discussion with Dr. William W. Robson, visiting professor of English from Lincoln college, Oxford university, on the "Foundation of Criticism."

The discussion will be held at 4:15 in 131 FH and will deal with the influence of the literary critic on Western civilization and the importance of a philosophy of criticism for educators. The panel will also discuss the fallacies of the critic in his approach to literature.

Both talks are sponsored by the School of Religion.

## Reservations Open for URA Fishing Trip Sat.

By Norm Nagre

Barracuda, sea bass, and yellow tail will be on the delicatessen 2 o'clock Saturday morning when a team of fishermen from SC invade the 3000 foot depths of the continental slope.

**There is room for 34 Trojans on the University Recreation Association deep sea fishing trip. Reservations can be made in the URA office, in 111 PE, for $5.50.**

The fishermen will leave SC at 1 a.m. Saturday and drive to the dock. The URA has hired a live-bait, deep sea boat. Trojans may rent fishing equipment at the dock for 50 cents and board the boat at 2. Trojans, bait, and equipment will go out to sea, pass the island of Catalina and drop anchor wherever the fish are running.

**On the last few fishing trips, said URA co-director Tillman Hall, the fishermen, most of them inexperienced, caught on the average of 3 fish per person. Hall said that this week the fish will be running in large numbers.**

Last year, Hall said, those inexperienced fishermen got seasick on their first at the same time. One of the other Trojans on board threw his bait line over the side of the boat as the seasick albacore were being pulled in. A pelican caught the bait and entangled all four lines. After forty minutes, lines were untangled and those albacore were pulled over the side of the boat.

**The group on the boat raises "kitties" of several dollars for the one who catches the biggest fish and the most fish, Hall said.**

Sometimes sharks go after the bait and scare other fish away. When this happens, the fishermen shoot the sharks and drive them away.

**Hall said the group will return to Los Angeles between 6 and 8 in the evening depending on fishing conditions. Last year there were so many fish caught that fishermen did not return till 10 at night.**

## Free Public Art Exhibit Opens Tonight at 8

Proving that a person doesn't have to be wealthy to be an art collector, an exhibit of material collected by students and teachers at SC will be on free public display in the Fisher "upstairs gallery" today through Aug. 7.

**There will be a public opening of the show tonight at 8 o'clock. Hours of the display will then be from 8 a.m. to 5 p.m. Monday through Friday.**

Ranging from pre-Columbian sculpture to contemporary painting, the collection of 35 students and teachers includes prints, fabrics, jewelry, ceramics, Oriental art, Africa native work, early Greek and 19th century Italian pieces. A wide range of periods and countries is represented to show what art the average person can collect.

**Wm. Paul Baker and Harvey Schaefer, graduate students in design, and Donald Goodall, head of the SC fine arts department, prepared the exhibit.**

## Troy Car Pool To Aid Both Drivers, Riders

**Do you want a breather from Los Angeles smog? Do you want to see San Francisco, New York, or Louisiana? Would you like a trip home?**

**Several Trojans are giving and looking for rides at the end of the summer session, Aug. 1. They want to cut down the cost of transportation by sharing expenses.**

**Mrs. Bernice Thys, Student Lounge hostess, directs the car pool at her desk in the lounge. Trojans may sign there for rides to almost every quarter of the United States.**

**The lounge is located on the third floor of the Student Union and is open every morning and evening.**

## Coffee Hour Wednesday

Every Wednesday afternoon from 3:00 to 4:30, the Graduate School sponsors a coffee hour in the new Graduate Lounge located in the basement of Town and Gown. This week the English Department will act as host. All Graduate Students are invited for coffee, tea, and donuts.

## UCLA Students to Discuss India Tomorrow in Doheny

"Project India" is to be discussed tomorrow at 3:15 p.m. in the Doheny Library art and lecture room.

**The discussion is part of the "Religion in Life" series sponsored by the School of Religion, University Chaplain Clinton A. Seyman, and the SC Protestant Advisor's association.**

Eleven UCLA students and two adults who spent nine weeks in India last summer will report tomorrow on their findings.

**They went to India for the purpose of putting on a personal campaign to help clear up the misunderstanding between the U.S. and that country. They spoke to 35,000 students at 135 colleges in India during the nine weeks.**

Since their return, they have been raising money for student literature and other projects.

PART OF THE 11 UCLA students who will be on campus tomorrow afternoon in the "Religion in Life" talk on India are left to right Victor Hacke, Joan Meyerovich, and Ernest Lightman. Standing is Rev. Cecil Hoffman.

## Official Notice

The French language exam for the Degree of Doctor of Philosophy will be given on July 31; the German exam will be given on July 31; and the Spanish exam will be given on July 31. All exams will be held at 7:15 in Room 228, Founders Hall.

Applications to take the test must be filed in the Graduate Office, Administration 216, during the week of July 13.

**FROM THE ARCHIVES** —The cover of a summer edition of the *Daily Trojan* on July 13, 1953. (Daily Trojan Archives / USC Libraries)

NATURE

# LA may be the new Cabo; we can't let that happen

*Shifting climates will change our ecological fabric, but our landscapes will tell if we'll make it out alive.*

DANIEL PONS

Nina Tomasevic / Daily Trojan

I never thought starting a backyard garden would send me into a philosophical doom spiral. It was an act that had me questioning the very tenets upon which I founded a large part of whom I wanted to become. Yet here I am.

For years now, my backyard has been an eroded badland birthed of sloth and neglect. The Dust Bowl would blush at its sight. So, I figured that I would take it upon myself to replant it with local, endogenous plants, given their adaptation to the local climate and conductivity to local biodiversity — basic layman stuff you could gather from Reddit.

That was until I stumbled upon a website detailing how climates can shift according to emissions trends. Little did I know I was about to enter Wonderland and be shown how deep the rabbit hole goes.

This site, "What will climate feel like in 60 years?", ruined me. It describes what the climates of American cities will feel like in 2080 if we continue pumping out greenhouse gasses at present rates. San Diego, my hometown, will resemble Los Angeles. And L.A. itself? We'll be a dead ringer for spring breakers' paradise Cabo San Lucas. Oh no.

I have spent all of my adult life obsessing over native plants. As an aspiring landscape architect, it's a proclivity that comes naturally; that's at least what I explain to concerned friends and family. While researching Southern California's plants and their ecological communities, I have come to the ethical conclusion that truly sustainable landscapes must reflect the plant communities immediately local to the site being planted. None of that "California native" bulrush — it's a caricaturization of a swath of ecological communities so vast it holds as much specificity as "Italian food."

But climate change — as it tends to do — severely complicates any preconceived notions of truth surrounding what plant selections would be appropriate for a given locale. The change blurs the very definition of nativity.

Generally, due to anthropogenically induced greenhouse gas emissions, climate zones are beginning to crawl away from the equator. For us in the Northern Hemisphere, that means that they're traveling north. Plants thus adapted over millions of years to a particular climate will find themselves ill-equipped to handle the new climate. Given that they don't have the option to pick up their skirts and skedaddle, specialized plants will likely begin to die out in the ensuing decades.

This news is especially troubling for me, as I tend to be a stubborn purist in most of my creative endeavors. I've even derided USC for picking out basic plant selections for their landscaping. Native my aster.

Globally, scientists have begun to take notice of this phenomenon, as many animal species are moving into ecosystems they have never previously inhabited. Grizzly bears are moving north and making sweet love to polar bears and producing pizzlys. Coral reefs are moving from the Caribbean to Galveston, Texas, and parrotfish are swimming into the Mediterranean. Others are exotic escapees, such as SoCal's famous parrots. While this movement of fauna itself carries a lot of questions — a "will they, won't they" of potential ecological destruction wrought by these climate migrants — the unfortunate fact is that many plants do not have these translocational capabilities.

Plants' best hope for survival is if their seeds hitch a ride on a traveling species, but plants won't be given that opportunity if endemic animals have already migrated. Humans, whether we like it or not, are tasked with cleaning up the mess we've made. And it's a different story for every city.

In the case of Los Angeles, being granted Cabo's climate is no gift. Sure, those suntanned spring break pictures you sent totally ate — I'm slaying this colloquial vernacular

thing — but it doesn't stay nice for long. Rather than our current year-round bliss and a moist rainy season, 2080's late summer will bring muggy, sweltering 91 degrees Fahrenheit heat and 2.5 inches of rain, while midday will bring heat exceeding 75 degrees throughout the year. Sure, winter will be drier, but the temperature will drive people inside regardless. Compounding this bad news, L.A.'s urban heat island effect will drive up the temperature a further 1-7 degrees Fahrenheit beyond what has been projected. Hope you like 83 degrees in December. Cabo in California isn't looking so great now, is it?

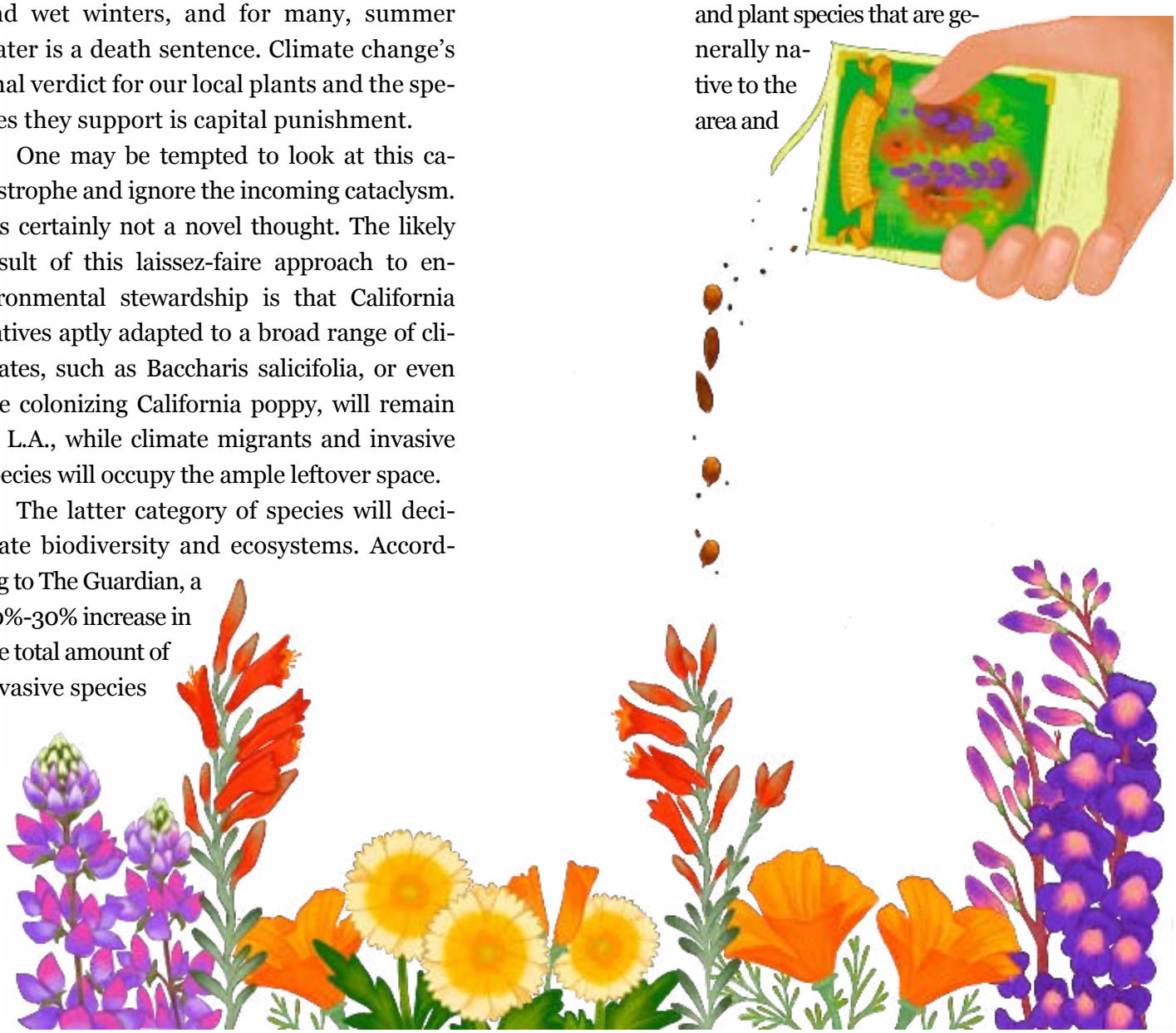
For native plants, the news is worse. L.A.'s natives have adapted to dry summers and wet winters, and for many, summer water is a death sentence. Climate change's final verdict for our local plants and the species they support is capital punishment.

One may be tempted to look at this catastrophe and ignore the incoming cataclysm. It's certainly not a novel thought. The likely result of this laissez-faire approach to environmental stewardship is that California natives aptly adapted to a broad range of climates, such as Baccharis salicifolia, or even the colonizing California poppy, will remain in L.A., while climate migrants and invasive species will occupy the ample leftover space.

The latter category of species will decimate biodiversity and ecosystems. According to The Guardian, a 20%-30% increase in the total amount of invasive species would be enough to cause global ecological collapse. Many invasive species afflicting California, such as cheatgrass, are known to cause fires that incinerate the competition, transforming what were once lush prairies into smoldering ashes ripe for takeover. It's how cheatgrass engulfed California's once-native grasslands. Fires themselves are projected to worsen with or without added help from invasive species, meaning their proliferation can only spell further doom.

So unless widespread wildfire and the loss of entire ecosystems becomes a good thing, it's best that we actually address the gap left by the plants that cannot cope.

Another option is to simply capitulate and plant species that are generally native to the area and



Miranda Davila / Daily Trojan

the state. In my experience, it's what most landscape hobbyists tend to do anyway. The thinking goes that if species are going to die out in the wild, at least in urban settings they will live on. So, Pitcher Sage from the Santa Monica Mountains will be put alongside Catalina Currant. It gives the landscaper the wherewithal to choose which plants to protect and conserve.

What's particularly infuriating is that the justification for these plantings I've heard is that shifting climates render true natives obsolete. A lot of native plant gardening is done under the guise of environmental consciousness but executed with caprice and whim. The plants ultimately chosen by hobbyists, for reasons I can't quite understand, are the ones most advertised.

If that weren't the case, then these gardeners would plant flora indigenous to Baja California Sur, but that would require research, which is the true crux of the argument.

Of course, either approach also has its deficits. Deprioritizing indigenous natives, and allowing for their local extinctions, would mean the extinction of many local species far too specialized to move with the climate. Los Angeles hosts two highly endangered butterflies, the El Segundo and the Palos Verdes blues; each named after the neighborhood to which its range is limited, each limited to one and two host plants, respectively.

These gorgeous butterflies, measuring the size of your thumbnail, would disappear due to landscaping efforts' focus on climate suitability rather than ecological value. The truth is, we can only save as much as we put our efforts into. There are ongoing campaigns to bolster these two butterflies' populations through habitat restoration, but if we're enduring Cabo's climate in 2080, their host plants may die out. And so will they.

As a last-ditch attempt, one could introduce genetically modified indigenous plants that are more adapted to the shifting climate, but the ramifications of this unprecedented kind of ecological intervention are completely unstudied. Given the outcomes of previously mentioned solutions, I don't imagine they're positive.

"THE TRUTH IS, WE CAN ONLY SAVE AS MUCH AS WE PUT OUR EFFORTS INTO."

The only viable solution to the landscaping conundrum is by addressing the problem at the root: Stop emitting greenhouse gasses, damn it. I shouldn't have to decide whether it's worth studying the plants native to this area because they'll go extinct by the end of the century. I shouldn't have to shift my efforts from making something beautiful to something that won't catch fire. I shouldn't have to worry about being able to enjoy a nice day outside in my golden years.

It's not enough to compensate for climate catastrophe with some harebrained scheme supposed to alleviate the problem. As long as climates shift, we will lose something. Maybe it'll be our homes in the greatest blaze ever recorded, maybe it'll be the smell of sage on a dewy June morning, maybe it'll be the very concept of a lazy August afternoon, or maybe it'll be the species that make a day out just that little more pleasant. If we don't do something, there won't be recovery from the scar we inflict upon the Earth.

On that website, there's a little button titled, "What if we reduce emissions?" Clicking it, I see that L.A.'s projected 2080 climate moves to Monterey Park. Maybe it's not all lost quite yet.

I've decided that I'm going to plant local natives in my garden, as though I gathered the seeds straight from the canyon down the road. Landscaping with anything else doesn't take into account the biodiversity, ecological or cultural components of landscaping with true natives. And it's a promise that we'll figure out a way to preserve the environment and keep ourselves accountable.

It's a promise of optimism. It's an uphill battle to protect threatened ecosystems, and even more so to replicate these ecosystems in landscaping projects, but then again, optimism was never easy in the first place. All we need are the seeds of hope.

*Daniel Pons was an opinion columnist and copy editor in Spring 2024. He is a rising junior majoring in geodesign.*

# Folt's five years

*It took mere weeks for the administration's decisions to tear the community apart. All eyes are on the president to build it back up.*

JONATHAN PARK

Henry Kofman / Daily Trojan

Shruti Shakthivel / Daily Trojan File Photo

"We're really living in the proverbial winds of change every day," President Carol Folt said, one early morning in March 2023. She was delivering that year's State of the University address. "Shifting demographics, the need for new foundational skills, the changing nature of work, the STEM revolution … These issues, and war, are sweeping us into a swirl of confusing signals."

These issues, and war. War, which at that point still meant the Russian invasion of Ukraine, used to be a footnote in a presidential term that was otherwise marked by acute optimism. She frequently spoke of "moonshots," a "limitless" future. Ambitious titles — "USC 3.0," "Frontiers of Computing" — headlined initiatives to revamp University programs, to reimagine sustainability, to center diversity. She took pride in rectifying this institution's horrific past in a sequence of largely symbolic but nonetheless affirming gestures. War used to be on the back burner.

## These issues, and war.

I write now, on the other side of Oct. 7, not only as a Trojan who has watched in abject horror as the Folt administration's choices have ripped apart an already tearing community but also as one of the three writers of an earlier profile of the president, published in this magazine in September. I can only speak for myself among those three writers, but in my contributions to that profile, at least, I had operated on a general sense of hope for this administration.

Of course, Folt has had her own litany of hot-button issues to reckon with: historic settlements for sexual abuse allegations

against George Tyndall, a growing movement toward unionization across several sectors, ongoing prosecutions of former University officials named in Operation Varsity Blues. And yes, there were heated moments where antisemitism — and anti-Zionism taken as antisemitism — took center stage. In 2020, the Undergraduate Student Government's pro-Israel vice president resigned following a campaign to remove her from office.

The next year, a Palestinian student was found to have tweeted that she wanted to "kill every motherfucking Zionist." In each of those incidents, Folt issued statements offering support for Jewish students and announcing initiatives — "Stronger than Hate" in 2020 and the Advisory Committee on Jewish Life in 2022.

But these controversies seemed to be isolated incidents, where a well-timed statement could give the University the freedom to wait out the storm. One could afford the privilege of looking past it all, of envisioning a bright future for this institution despite the setbacks.

There has been no such opportunity since October. For one thing, there is quite simply no easy way out. Israel's brutal onslaught on Gaza seems to have no end in sight. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Sunday that the "intense phase of war with Hamas" is "about to end," though he was clear he would not accept a "partial" ceasefire if he thought it would have the power to end the current war.

Folt learned the hard way that this would not be a matter of simply issuing a statement; after stumbling over her initial community message regarding "the horror in Israel and Gaza," she stayed deathly silent on the matter for the next several months, perhaps fearing another public-relations crisis.

"I DON'T FEEL SO INCLINED TO EXTEND ANY SYMPATHY TO THE PRESIDENT. THE BLAME FOR ALL THE CHAOS, ALL THE CONFUSION AND ALL THE ANGER THAT THIS ADMINISTRATION'S DECISIONS HAVE WROUGHT UPON THE COMMUNITY ARE PRINCIPALLY ON HER SHOULDERS."

Yet I don't feel so inclined to extend any sympathy to the president. The blame for all the chaos, all the confusion and all the anger that this administration's decisions have wrought upon the community are principally on her shoulders.

When the Gaza Solidarity Occupation forced Folt's hand, her administration showed its true colors. When the University decided to rain the hellfire of law enforcement on a peaceful protest at Alumni Park, only to then have Folt backpedal weeks later, saying she regretted not speaking with students earlier, the hypocrisy and cowardice were quite apparent — perhaps most of all to the Academic Senate, to whom Folt had made that claim, mere hours after which the faculty body decided to censure her and Provost Andrew Guzman.

When Asna Tabassum dared to put a link in her Instagram bio, Folt's administration showed its true colors. When Folt and Guzman chose to raze the main commencement ceremony to the ground rather than let a pro-Palestinian hijabi woman speak, when they chose to hide behind — and stick with — a limp excuse of "safety" that threw Jewish students under the bus and hardly aligned with USC's own history of hosting high-profile and controversial people, the hypocrisy and cowardice were, again, quite apparent, and this time to the entire graduating class and those who planned to attend commencement.

As the complaints grew louder and louder, we watched as this University stripped away the mainstage ceremony bit by bit: first the valedictorian, then the outside speakers, then the entire ceremony. It is no wonder that, rather than face the music, Folt relegated the makeshift "Trojan Family Graduate Celebration" to the Los Angeles Memorial Coliseum — a venue so large

that any protests would have been rendered a speck — and delivered no remarks.

July is now just around the corner, and the Trousdale North Entrance is still fenced shut. Security Ambassadors are still posted at the few open entrances, scanning USC IDs. The @uscedu Instagram account mustered up the courage to open up their comment sections again, and the results are just as expected. Under a bare-bones Juneteenth graphic jointly posted with @usc_athletics — "A day of celebration, education and reflection. Happy Juneteenth, #TrojanFamily!" — the top comment: "Yes, please educate us. Anything in particular come up during your time of reflection?"

Insofar as the Trojan Family is a family, it has become an increasingly dysfunctional one, and it will take nothing short of a miracle to bring us back together. Not another statement vaguely mentioning the "conflict in the Middle East," not another violent police crackdown in the name of "safety," and certainly not another embarrassing meltdown over a valedictorian. And most of all, not the tired strategy of laying low again and hoping the whole thing will blow over in time, as it always used to. Rather, I dare to dream of an administration that can look its students, faculty and staff in the eye and say it supports us, all of us, and act like it. That is, after all, what an administration is meant to do. And yet, given what we have witnessed and where we are now, accomplishing that would indeed be something of a miracle.

*Jonathan Park was digital managing editor in Spring 2024. He is a rising senior majoring in applied and computational mathematics.*

Shruti Shakthivel / Daily Trojan File Photo

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

# Our queer leaders cannot be collateral

*President Carol Folt, Vice President for Student Life Monique Allard and Assistant Vice Provost for Student Life, Student Equity and Inclusion Naddia Palacios, we charge you with perpetuating homophobic violence.*

THE STUDENT COMMUNITY OF THE LGBTQ+ STUDENT CENTER AND JUSTICE EQUITY DIVERSITY INCLUSION AT USC

To President Carol Folt; Vice President for Student Life Monique Allard; and Assistant Vice Provost for Student Life, Student Equity and Inclusion Naddia Palacios:

We are shocked, pained and horrified that two queer members of the Student Life Free Expression team, Megan van der Toorn and Kiara Dade, have been used to attack and silence students within the USC Divest From Death Coalition.

A significant portion of the students participating in the Gaza Solidarity Occupation were queer; and yet, van der Toorn — director of Student Equity and Inclusion Programs Intercultural Services, including gender equity programs and the LGBTQ+ Student Center — and Dade — coordinator for Justice Equity Diversity Inclusion Programs — have been harbingers of the administrative regulations which deprived students of basic needs such as safety and protection from police brutality. They've witnessed firsthand the intimidation and suppression by the USC Department of Public Safety, and yet their roles on the Free Expression team constrain them to spewing rhetoric about "acceptable" forms of protest.

During the encampment, van der Toorn and Dade acted under the guise of liaisons, communicating with student negotiators with the veiled intention of forcing students to decamp. They continually prefaced with concerns for our safety and well-being, while making decisions that compounded the trauma we experienced on the first day of the encampment, such as prohibiting students from using blankets while sprinklers went off the entire night. They also positioned themselves as incapable of intervening in DPS' intimidation tactics and violence, but they had both the duty and agency to speak out against the countless cases of physical assault and careless life endangerment of students. Just hours after the encampment began, footage spread of DPS officers assaulting a Palestinian student organizer, putting him in a chokehold and pinning him to the ground with a knee to his neck, a police tactic that is against DPS policy: "Please note, DPS does not authorize the use of lateral vascular or other neck restraints." There is no doubt Kiara and Megan had access to this footage, and yet — instead of stepping in when students were brutalized once again that night — they ignored students' pleas for lessening DPS engagement. They refused to even acknowledge how traumatizing and unjustifiable DPS's use of force was when student liaisons (all of whom who are queer) shared their experiences with them.

By serving as tools of a fascist administration, van der Toorn and Dade have willingly allowed themselves to be weaponized, tokenized and reduced to mere instruments of control, all while cloaked in the language of equity and inclusion. As they attempt to maintain the facade of neutrality, they embody the insidious role of peace police, where the oppressed are manipulated into policing their own. This is a continuation of USC's long history of institutionalized homophobia and violent suppression, exemplified by the 2022 settlement involving the abuse of queer students by Dennis Kelly.

The concept of "Student Affairs" was a Nixon-era policy following the Kent State massacre to install a buffer between university administrations and their student bodies through cultural intermediaries to quell student frustration and anger. Under the distant direction of Allard through the mobilization of trusted queer intermediaries — van der Toorn and Dade — USC Student Affairs has lived up to its intended purpose: to pacify the students who are demanding change and enable President Folt to nefariously

misrepresent what students communicate to justify the militarized police violence and brutality.

The pinkwashed tactics Folt's administration uses to pit queer leaders against their own students serve only to suppress the reality: A disproportionate number of those who have been abused by USC's aggressive actions toward protesters are queer. Our students were critically misgendered and violated by Folt engaging the paramilitary Los Angeles Police Department forces, which has historically been mobilized to violently dismantle queer liberation organizations. If the admin did not know the majority of protesters were queer, why did they only send two queer SEIP staff as the primary liaisons?

"DPS hasn't ever made queer USC students feel safe," said a USC junior who participated in the encampment and spoke on the condition of anonymity out of fear for their safety. "I remember when my friends and I were sitting on the lawn, and a group of officers yelled out 'faggots' at us. When we yelled back, they came and checked our IDs just to flex their power. That's targeted and intentional queerphobia. It's indicative of how police forces marginalize queer students and jeopardize their sense of safety on campus."

Since the beginning of the encampment, the fourth floor has been silent. No one is at the SEIP centers because they have been at the encampments, at citywide protests and standing beside the other queer students of color at universities across Southern California. It is insulting and facetious the way Folt's administration is attempting to celebrate Pride Month weeks after they barred queer students of color from their only housing, from their graduations and from their communities. There is no pride in genocide.

"We're having conversations across multiple identities in Student Equity and Inclusion Programs. I want to be intentional about intersectionality and expand our offerings for students to explore gender, gender identity, and gender equity during their time at USC," said Palacios in an interview with USC Today just one year ago.

We'd like to respond by calling this statement what it truly is: utter flatulence. Despite her history of working in violence prevention and advocacy, Palacios has deployed our queer leaders against students, led police to brutalize students and has done the direct opposite of "supporting" us. For Folt and Palacios, our lives and voices are collateral for their careers.

"For many of us, the LGBTQ+ Student Center has been the first and only safe space we've had at USC," said another USC junior who spoke on the condition of anonymity out of fear of retaliation. "Megan was someone who I really related to and respected, so this felt like a stab in the back."

For many students coming from social environments where being openly

"I REMEMBER WHEN MY FRIENDS AND I WERE SITTING ON THE LAWN, AND A GROUP OF [DPS] OFFICERS YELLED OUT 'FAGGOTS' AT US. WHEN WE YELLED BACK, THEY CAME AND CHECKED OUR IDS JUST TO FLEX THEIR POWER."

. . .

**USC JUNIOR**

*Member of USC Divest From Death's "Gaza Solidarity Occupation"*

and explicitly queer was largely discouraged, the center presented a new space where many of us felt we could express ourselves in totality. Now, people who have previously presented themselves as "one of us" have been set firmly in opposition. Van der Toorn is a role model who students admire as an openly lesbian adult in a position of power. The same goes for Dade, who coordinates intercultural and justice-based workshops at USC and works with students at the Center for Black Cultural and Student Affairs.

"I have watched Kiara advocate for change by educating our classmates about what it means to pursue justice, equity, diversity and inclusion," said a USC senior who spoke on the condition of anonymity due to fear for their safety. "Seeing them be used to further student injustice and intimidation enacted by the administration feels contradictory. Now, I am not sure how to navigate conversations with them. I am not sure how or if this trust can be rebuilt."

This treacherous complicity represents a stark betrayal of our queer community and its radical, liberatory lineage. The recent actions of these leaders diverge from the long history of queer liberation marked by disruptive demonstrations like the riots at Compton's Cafeteria to The Black Cat Tavern protests and the infamous Stonewall Rebellion. By using its queer leaders to project their own pacifying objectives, the administration has betrayed the trust of its queer students and weakened these invaluable bonds. By placing the responsibility of student suppression onto two queer women leaders in our space, you force them into a corner of contradiction.

VAN DER TOORN AND DADE'S ACTIONS HAVE MATERIAL CONSEQUENCES, REINFORCING THE ADMINISTRATION'S POWER AND PERPETUATING SYSTEMIC HARM ALL WHILE QUEER STUDENTS ARE STRIPPED OF HOUSING, EMPLOYMENT, AND EDUCATION.

Van der Toorn and Dade's actions have material consequences, reinforcing the administration's power and perpetuating systemic harm all while queer students are stripped of housing, employment, and education. This is a manifestation of a broader strategy to dismantle and depoliticize our movements. We must recognize and resist these tactics, reclaiming our power and reaffirming our commitment to collective liberation.

We call on readers to demand that USC stop weaponizing our SEIP leaders to suppress the free speech of student protesters. Instead of turning our trusted mentors from all of our cultural centers against our community, the administration must let them do their job, which is to support students, not oppress us. Whether you're queer or an ally, we ask you to email Naddia Palacios demanding that she release SEIP staff from free expression duties and stop mobilizing against protesters.

Folt, Allard and Palacios — the students, staff and faculty are putting you on the stand. Now you must answer: Who do you serve?

*The Student Community of the LGBTQ+ Student Center and Justice Equity Diversity Inclusion at USC is a group of undergraduates who are not affiliated with the* Daily Trojan. *The group's letter does not represent the views of the* Daily Trojan*'s staff.*

COMMUNITY

# Playing with Pride

*Queer athletes and fans discuss what Pride Month means to them.*

JENNIFER NEHRER

Bryce Dechert / Daily Trojan

5
DON
T&T

On June 3, Maggie Ramsay — a rising junior on the USC women's lacrosse team — spoke in a prerecorded message about the importance of safe spaces for queer joy as a part of the USC Pride Month Kickoff celebration. However much like other athletes in this piece, Ramsay is more than that 50-second video.

Ramsay grew up in Darien, Connecticut — a town she called a "homophobic" and "very white privilege place." She played several sports in high school — soccer, basketball and lacrosse — before committing to USC for the latter. She said she chose USC to follow her older sister, Katie, who was also on the team — but also to escape to an environment where she knew she would be supported.

"I knew how accepting my [USC] coaching staff was," Ramsay said in an interview with the *Daily Trojan*. "When I was doing all that stuff my senior year of high school, they reached out to me, told me how proud of me they were … My sister committed when I was in sixth grade, and I kind of decided that day that I was going to follow in her footsteps and try to make it happen."

Another reason Ramsay was intent on leaving for Los Angeles was around the time she committed to USC in her junior year of high school, Ramsay had been outed as gay and was facing harassment from her peers.

"The f-slur was thrown around at me a bunch in school, out of school," Ramsay said. "I had parents who said to their kids, 'I don't really want you hanging around Maggie anymore,' just because I was gay. I've had drinks poured on my head."

Ramsay said she had to leave friend groups composed of athletes who turned

**MAGGIE RAMSAY** – a rising junior on the USC women's lacrosse team – chose USC to to escape to an environment where she knew she would be supported as a gay woman. (Emma Silverstein / Daily Trojan File Photo)

against her after being outed. But she found better friends who accepted her and would help her advocate for herself and others. Since she was in high school, Ramsay has spoken at board of education and select board meetings to advocate for better treatment of queer students in the area, as well as related issues.

## PROUD ATHLETES: A (BRIEF) HISTORY

The first athlete on a professional "team sport" in the United States did not come out until around 50 years ago. David Kopay, who had played for five NFL teams, came out during an interview with *The Washington Star* in 1975 — three years after he had retired. Glenn Burke, a former Los Angeles Dodger and Oakland Athletic known for popularizing the high-five during his career in the '70s, came out during an interview in 1993.

More athletes participating in solo sports have come out in the late 1900s. Martina Navratilova, a Czech American tennis player, came out as bisexual in 1981. Though she subsequently faced discrimination from potential sponsors, she remained outspoken on queer issues and went on to win 167 singles tennis tournaments. Another tennis great, Billie Jean King, who recently spoke at the Annenberg School for Communication and Journalism's commencement ceremony, was outed that same year.

In recent years, the prevalence and coverage of queer athletes in all sports has grown. The 2020 Tokyo Summer Olympics (which occurred in 2021) included the first out transgender and nonbinary Olympians, and in November 2021, the International Olympic Committee issued new guidelines protecting LGBTQIA+ athletes, including directions for governing sports bodies to fairly construct future competitions to limit discrimination based on gender identity.

Carl Nassib, then a defensive end for the Las Vegas Raiders, became the first active NFL player to come out as gay in 2021. That same year, then-Nashville Predators prospect Luke Prokop became the first openly gay player in NHL history. Sue Bird and Megan Rapinoe, titans in their respective sports of basketball and soccer, have been openly together since 2017.

Zach Herrin, a NASCAR driver, grew up in a family of motorsports. His father picked it up as a "weekend hobby," but it quickly became the driving force behind his and his brother's careers. Herrin said in an interview with the *Daily Trojan* that he began riding motorcycles at the age of 5 and made a professional debut at 16.

Unfortunately for him, he would soon step back from racing for the next 10 years. Herrin left professional racing when he came out to his friends and family because he felt that he couldn't balance growing into his true self with staying in a sport that he said wasn't very accepting in an interview with The Advocate.

"I felt like my career was, in a way, taken from me," he said. "[I was] just struggling mentally with not finding acceptance in hiding my true personality than a sport that I loved for so many years. It was the hardest time."

Nearly a decade later, in November 2022, Herrin returned — though he faced a renewed challenge: getting funds. With few sponsors or other sources of money, Herrin found it hard at first to race as much as he wanted.

"If you [are a] driver who has family or personal funding, you can have a career," he said. "If you don't have that, you need corporate sponsorship. For someone like me, who currently has neither, it's almost impossible."

Herrin hopes as companies are increasing their sponsorships of queer events and initiatives, they will break into the motorsport realm and work with him.

In the meantime, Herrin is happy with the progress that NASCAR is making in terms of allyship. Specifically, he praised the company Ally — also a major sponsor for Angel City F.C. — for being a driving force in putting together NASCAR's Pride events and sponsoring a car on the track. The car, driven by Alex Bowman, was part

**ZACH HERRIN** — a NASCAR driver — left professional racing when he came out to his friends and family because he felt that he couldn't balance growing into his true self with staying in a sport that he said wasn't very accepting. (Bryce Dechert / Daily Trojan)

of NASCAR powerhouse Hendrick Motorsports, which had another one of its cars take first place at the June 10 Sonoma race where the Ally car also drove.

"I've been manifesting and obviously doing a lot of work side by side with them this year," Herrin said. "One day [I'll] have an Ally car with my name on it, we'll see."

And as for discrimination on or off the road, Herrin said he hasn't seen as much as some might think. He said those who may have a problem simply see themselves out.

"There's not that much hate," he said. "There's been a lot of headlines in the past that [paint] that picture, but it's really changing and evolving. And as one side of the country continues to evolve with this whole cancel culture thing and 'we don't approve of this,' they just eliminate themselves and then new people have more room to come in and grow together."

More recently, the WNBA has seen progress. Layshia Clarendon, a guard for the Los Angeles Sparks as well as the first WNBA player to come out as transgender and nonbinary, told the *Daily Trojan* that the league's efforts to celebrate pride have been appropriate and uplifting. Incidentally, one of Clarendon's former coaches is current USC women's basketball Head Coach Lindsay Gottlieb.

"It's very reflective of the WNBA, of the people in this league," said Clarendon, who is also the first active WNBA player to have gotten top surgery. "It's amazing to see, especially in this moment in time where there's so many anti-trans bills or so much legislation around trying to exclude the queer community, specifically trans people from being in sports. So it means a lot, but it's kind of a no-brainer for your org to support people."

After WNBA league play began in 1997, it took a few years for the first athlete — Sue Wicks of the New York Liberty in 2002 — to come out. Slowly, the league became more and more outwardly accepting. In 2014, it became the first profes-

**BRITTANY SHAW** – a longtime supporter of Angel City F.C., appreciates the fact that the women's soccer community is generally very welcoming to queer fans and players. (Bryce Dechert / Daily Trojan)

**MAJOR LEAGUE TEAMS** around the country have begun holding "Pride nights" in June to celebrate the queer community and queer athletes. (Bryce Dechert / Daily Trojan)

sional sports league to announce a yearly pride campaign featuring a televised pride game. By 2017, an article by "Just Women's Sports" notes, it was no longer an "expectation" for players to announce their sexuality — and the league continues to evolve.

In 2022, one year after their own gender-affirming surgery, Clarendon started the Layshia Clarendon Foundation, which aims to provide those in need with "access to life affirming healthcare and wellness services" through a number of methods, including financial support and education.

With a love for their community both on and off the court, Clarendon said in their interview with the *Daily Trojan* that queer aspiring athletes should be able to have the "beautiful" experience of being on a team, especially one that is welcoming.

"Don't miss out on the beautiful opportunity to be a part of a team," they said. "Care about your safety and your wellness with choosing when to come out and making sure you have people around you that will support you, that's the most important thing. But for me, basketball has been one of the safest places and the places that have given me so much community and joy with other people."

## ATHLETIC PRIDE IN LOS ANGELES

Major league teams around the country have begun holding "Pride nights" in June to celebrate the queer community and queer athletes. Though some have experienced controversy — such as a Dodgers LGBTQ+ Pride Night in 2023, which faced backlash when the Dodgers initially caved to calls from Catholic groups to exclude a charity group of queer nuns in drag — queer fans are generally pleased with the opportunity to celebrate themselves.

Brittany Shaw, a longtime supporter of Angel City F.C., appreciates the fact that the women's soccer community is generally very welcoming to queer fans and players. Though she did not specifically attend a Pride night, rainbow flags could be seen throughout the stadium and she herself was decked out in rainbow-clad gear.

"Women's soccer, it's very queer," Shaw said. "It's very pro-LGBTQ+, it's very welcoming. It's a great place, and

you see a lot of families, a lot of kids and it's just really special because everyone accepts everyone as they are."

## TROJAN PRIDE

Back at USC, Ramsay majors in political science — which she said she chose because of her life in Darien. She is also the co-president of the University's chapter of Athlete Ally, a nationwide organization for queer athletes. Ramsay said Julie Rousseau, the associate athletic director in charge of diversity, equity and inclusion at USC, helped her to start the USC chapter within the last year. Before establishing the chapter, Ramsay went to a summit for the organization, which she described as an incredible experience.

"We [were] surrounded by other queer athletes," she said. "I've never felt so safe, and I've made so many friends at this place."

Since its recent creation, the USC chapter has amassed around 25 student-athletes and held a few successful bonding events, such as a dodgeball game and an ice cream social.

"It was nice to get to meet other queer athletes," she said. "I obviously knew some just from the dining hall, but when you are on a team you mostly spend most of your time with your team. And so it's really nice interacting with other athletes on different teams. I've loved it. It's been an amazing experience."

Ramsay said her teammates and coaches have continued to support her. They've donned Pride shirts to match ones her parents have worn and brandished rainbow sweatbands on National Coming Out Day.

"The constant support in my identity has always been here at USC, and that is something I so badly needed in high school, and I think it is needed everywhere. But I'm so lucky and so grateful to have it here at USC now," she said.

Ramsay's biggest supporter, however, is likely her mother, who she said she looks up to because of her fervent support of Ramsay and the community. Her mother has spoken at the same board meetings and offered words of comfort when a campaign hasn't gone the way they wanted.

"The way that she fights for what she believes is right is just unbelievable," Ramsay said. "She will invite her like-minded friends over, and they will sit at the kitchen table and write letters to people, urging them to vote … [to] overturn this flag policy [which prohibited the pride flag from being flown above the town hall], for example."

For aspiring queer athletes, or anyone stuck in a tough situation, Ramsay has four words: "It does get better."

"I'd wake up every day and be like, 'It's okay, you're out of here soon, you're out of here soon,'" she said. "It sucks that some people in some places, like myself in Darien, have to feel like that, but it does get better."

She also praised sports for being her saving grace while she was still in Connecticut. Being a force on the field meant those who wanted her out had to admire her skill.

"It's not easy growing up in a place where you're not accepted, and it's constantly shown, but I always felt like an equal on the sports field," she said. "It was like, 'Oh, if you're good, you're fine.' And so I guess I just practiced my craft so that no one could say anything about me, because no one cared as long as I could do my job in the field, no one cared who I loved."

Ultimately, Ramsay said her experience was worth going through because it showed her what authenticity means and made her even more proud to be the best version of herself.

"Even though I went through a lot when I came out, I don't think I would ever change what happened to me," she said. "I've loved getting to be the truest version of myself. I look in the mirror every day, and I'm happy with that, and I'm very proud of myself for getting to that spot, because I haven't always been there. [Know] that it's okay to not be there right now, but [know] that you will get there eventually and have that pride in yourself and then love yourself for every bit of your identity, whether that's being an athlete, being queer, or anything in between."

*Bryce Dechert contributed to this report.*

*Jennifer Nehrer was the News assignments editor in Spring 2024. She is a rising junior majoring in journalism.*

CULTURE

# Armenian History Month at USC — 100 years in the making

*A conversation with the people, events and emotions behind the now University-supported month-long celebration of Armenian culture.*

JENNIFER NEHRER

Jennifer Nehrer / Daily Trojan

Every fall, the campus of the University of Southern California is vibrant and full of energy on football game days. Thousands of students, alumni, friends and family swarm campus as early as they can — partying on college grounds for hours before making the pilgrimage across Exposition Boulevard to the Los Angeles Memorial Coliseum. Tailgate tents take up nearly every inch of the University Park Campus, with the most frequented and student-run ones claiming the peak real estate that is McCarthy Quad.

Among them, flying high above the crowds, is an Armenian flag. It belongs to the tent designated for the USC Armenian Students' Association and its guests, a group which makes up a sizable portion of the USC community, but has often felt its representation at the University has been inadequate — until this month.

For the first time, USC is recognizing April as Armenian History Month, an effort that many say was months in the making and long overdue.

## A PROMINENT COMMUNITY

Los Angeles is home to the largest Armenian community outside of Armenia itself, with a population of over 200,000 Armenians and counting. They are a diasporic people, scarred by the genocide against them in 1915, and the years of cruelty they have faced since at the hands of Turkey and Azerbaijan.

Armenians leaving the Ottoman Empire in the late 1800s settled throughout the United States, but Fresno, California, was particularly enticing because of its agricultural similarities to the land they had left. Slowly, then, these communities moved towards the urban draw of L.A.

In September 2023, Azeri forces launched attacks against the Nagorno-Karabakh region of Armenia — known to Armenians as the ancestral land of Artsakh — killing many residents and forcing many more to flee.

Around the same time, the USC Center for Public Diplomacy hosted the Turkish Ambassador to the United States Hasan Murat Mercan at a "Türkiye Conference" at Annenberg Hall. Unbeknownst to the University, the ambassador brought with him Ramil Gurbanov, consul general of Azerbaijan in Los Angeles.

Upon hearing of this event, Armenians at USC and in L.A. were furious, demanding that the event be canceled and, when it went on, protesting for hours both inside and outside the venue. In the aftermath, an investigation by the *Daily Trojan* revealed USC's hidden response to the conference, as well as to the elected officials who had condemned it.

But, as multiple people told me, that is not how Armenians want to be remembered.

## THE FACES OF ARMENIA AT USC

When she was 10 years old, Shushan Karapetian immigrated to the United States with her family from Yerevan, the capital of Armenia, which at the time was under Soviet rule. They moved to Los Angeles to join an uncle of hers who already lived there. Speaking little English, Karapetian was worried that she would have a rough time integrating and assimilating into Southern California culture. But when she joined her new school, she found many of her classmates were Armenian as well.

"People always say, 'Well, was there a culture shock?' There really wasn't," she said. "It was a very soft, gradual integration, if one may call it that."

After earning her bachelor's, master's and doctoral degrees from UCLA, Karapetian is now the director of the University of Southern California's Institute of Armenian Studies, one of the most in-depth academic ventures representing USC and Los Angeles' sizable Armenian community. Karapetian had originally intended to become an anthropologist and do field work in Armenia. Instead, she said, Armenia came to her.

"It all worked out miraculously," Karapetian said. "I was living in the city that was becoming the capital of the Armenian diaspora, and I was at the university that had the best Armenian studies program in the world."

Though UCLA has its own robust Armenian studies program, USC "wooed" Karapetian five years ago.

Karapetian and I had a long conversation, during which she told me about her time at USC and how she

connected with the Armenian community in Los Angeles. What she didn't tell me, however, is that the University has her to thank for the most vocal member of the Armenian Students' Association: Mané Berikyan.

Berikyan, a junior majoring in international relations as well as Russian, moved with her family to the San Fernando Valley when she was seven years old. Her father was a diplomat at the Armenian embassy in Buenos Aires, Argentina, and when he got his Green Card, the family first had to return to Armenia — where they lived — to retrieve their belongings.

Berikyan did not have many Armenian friends in school — a factor which pushed her to look for a college with a strong Armenian community.

USC was that place. But she almost went to UC Berkeley, which had originally been a first choice for her. So she spoke to Karapetian, asking for advice, as the latter had also almost gone upstate.

To Berikyan's shock, Karapetian — then in the infancy of her career at the University — told her to come to USC. So she did.

In an attempt to join early, Berikyan told me that she sent a message to the USC ASA Instagram account before classes had even started. It worked. She joined the ASA's executive board as a sophomore, is their vice president now as a junior, and on April 29 she was elected to serve as their President beginning Fall 2024.

ASA's cultural chair is Sophia Chorbajian, a senior majoring in business administration. The organization's cultural showcase on April 9 was her proverbial baby — an idea she'd come up with while running for the position last year.

Like Berikyan, Chorbajian grew up in the Valley. Seeking recognition for her people, Chorbajian told me she would work with the schools she attended to recognize the Armenian Genocide and Armenian History Month, including the community colleges around her alma mater, Moorpark College.

"When I came here, I definitely had the idea in mind to work on a similar kind of initiative here at USC's campus," she said.

Manuk Avedikyan, project manager at the Institute of Armenian Studies, learned English from watching Nickelodeon. Though he was born and raised all over L.A., his parents were Turkish Armenian immigrants who ran a pharmacy in which the majority of customers were Armenians from all walks of life.

It was there, and when he would make personal visits to customers' homes to deliver medication, that he would talk with them about their heritage — which, along with his attendance at Armenian cultural events in his community, spurred his interest in studying Armenia and its cultures.

His parents sent him to Armenian schools before he earned his bachelor's at California State University Northridge. After attending CSUN, Avedikyan went to the American University of Armenia for his master's degree.

"That was a great experience because what better place to study Armenians or Armenia than in Armenia?" he asked. "And what better place to study the region than being in the region?"

After moving back to L.A., Avedikyan had coffee with an employee of the USC Shoah Foundation. Soon after that, he had a job there: He began as an indexer, but eventually led the team working on the Armenian Genocide Interview Collections at the Institute.

When the Institute received a $1 million grant from the California State Library to create a project called "California History Through Armenian Experiences," Avedikyan left the Shoah Foundation to lead the new initiative with the Institute of Armenian Studies — which he still does today.

## RECOGNITION

USC's recognition of Armenian history is rare among U.S. institutions, but not unique. In 2021, President Joe Biden formally recognized the Armenian genocide on behalf of the country for the first time since it occurred 106 years ago. The U.S. Senate also passed a resolution by unanimous consent to recognize it in 2019.

In late 2022, the L.A. County Board of Supervisors moved to officially recognize April as Armenian History Month and April 24 as "Armenian Genocide Remembrance Day in Los Angeles County." In the same year, California Governor Gavin Newsom declared April 24 a statewide "Genocide Awareness Day."

**DR. SHUSHAN KARAPETIAN**, director of the USC Institute for Armenian Studies, left the Soviet Union with her family when she was 10 years old. (Jennifer Nehrer / Daily Trojan)

**MANÉ BERIKYAN**, vice president of the USC Armenian Students' Association, said she messaged the USC ASA Instagram account to get involved a week before classes had begun her freshman year. (Jennifer Nehrer / Daily Trojan)

**MANUK AVEDIKYAN**, project manager at the USC Institute for Armenian Studies, earned his master's degree at the American University of Armenia. (Jennifer Nehrer / Daily Trojan)

Where USC is unique is its recognition of Armenian History Month as an institute of higher education. While Avedikyan said that UCLA has a robust Armenian Studies program, the physical presence of the Institute at USC — where a good amount of the month's events have been held — has an advantage when it comes to visible recognition.

"UCLA has the most developed Armenian studies program in the West Coast, maybe even all over the U.S., but it doesn't have a space. We have a space. And that's a real privilege of sorts. It's something that we capitalize on," he said.

Berikyan, who is also executive chair of the All-Armenian Students' Association — a nonprofit that connects ASAs across the world — told me that while other universities have some administrative support in their Armenian History Month celebrations, she believes USC is the first and only to have direct administrative involvement in making the celebrations happen on a higher level — celebrations which took considerable effort to put in place.

## HOW IT HAPPENED

While most USC community members learned of Armenian History Month in March as celebrations were announced, many had been planning April's events for a very long time.

Berikyan told me that she was inspired to push for the recognition of Armenian History Month due to the multitude of other history and heritage months that USC hosts. She said she figured given the size of the Armenian population at USC, they deserved one as well.

"I noticed that USC did all these cultural heritage months, which I thought was great, and it was an amazing way for communities to sort of get recognition and visibility," Berikyan said. "I realized that we have a huge population of Armenian students here who are very involved and active in all parts of student life, but we don't get any of that sort of recognition or visibility on campus."

Berikyan said she spoke with Karapetian sometime last year and decided that there would be an Armenian History Month at USC, come hell or high water. It was in September, then, that the two involved Chorbajian and other members of the ASA executive board, as well as people from the Institute, and began speaking with the USC administration about getting things off the ground. In January, the University gave the OK for ASA and IAS to run their celebrations — with USC's stamp of approval

.

## LOOKING BACK...

When I asked Karapetian about the events in September, her demeanor changed. It was the same way she had spoken of the 1915 genocide, and the recent forced dissolution of Artsakh. She avoided my eyes, and her speech slowed.

"The community was both grieving what was happening to their kin, grieving the loss of a homeland outraged by the silence of the international powers and media, and at the same time, just shocked and outraged at what was happening on their own campus," she said.

Nevertheless, Karapetian is excited. After months of planning with the USC Armenian Students' Association and the Institute, the month has come around. Though this is not the first time this month has ever been honored — Karapetian noted that the Glendale school district has no classes on Armenian Genocide Remembrance Day each year — this is a first for a university campus and she already knows it is setting a precedent for others.

"I have already received notes and comments and calls and excited messages from peers all over saying, 'What a great idea! I wish we had this on our campus,' or, 'I'd love to see this on my campus,'" Karapetian said.

Along the same vein, Berikyan said she was thrilled. It's been an emotional month, she told me, in a good way.

"There's a lot of history that the Armenian community has made at USC that I think often goes unnoticed even by our own community," she said. "So especially being in a place of academia where Armenians have contributed so much to making USC what it is today, I think that that's especially important."

Chorbajian kept describing the experience of gaining recognition on campus to me as "surreal." She spoke to me about the contributions Armenians have made to USC; notably Ronald Tutor — formerly Varjabedian, the armenian word for "teacher" — whose father anglicized their

**SOPHIA CHORBJIAN**, cultural chair of the USC Armenian Students' Association, worked with administrations at every school she attended to recognize the Armenian Genocide and Armenian History Month. (Jennifer Nehrer / Daily Trojan)

last name after people around him struggled to pronounce it; and Zohrab Kaprielian, of Kaprielian Hall, who held multiple administrative roles at USC in the 1970s — and how this month was a simple yet profound recognition of that.

"We've been around campus for over 100 years, and that's something not even all our members knew. Half the time you're so caught up just going to class and going to school that you forget about the bigger picture," she said. "It's definitely been a very rewarding experience."

Avedikyan is similarly excited, as he said this Armenian History Month is special because the University is truly recognizing its Armenian students, staff and faculty. He also appreciated the fact that USC is recognizing the entire month as opposed to one day.

"It's a small series of events, but it's the beginning of ... what could potentially take place later on in the future," he said.

## ... AND LOOKING FORWARD

So, what is next?

For starters, next year's Armenian History Month celebrations will be officially on USC's "docket" — meaning the University will directly assist in event planning, create banners to be put around campus, send University-wide emails for events and more. With this assistance, Berikyan and others hope next year will be bigger and better.

"We have some really exciting ideas for events that will showcase Armenian culture, celebrate it and invite the outside community, which is something that's very important to us to also be involved in the celebrations," she said.

When I asked her for an example of such an event, she told me she wants to host an all-day Armenian and fusion food festival.

"We have a lot of very talented chefs in the L.A. area, because it's such a big hub for Armenian diaspora culture," she said. "We can invite food trucks and really well-known chefs and that sort of thing, because I think food is something that will invite bigger audiences."

But no one I spoke to wants it to stop at USC.

"We're seeing schools like UCLA, UC Irvine, [Loyola Marymount University], ones globally that are also making preparations to not only mark a student-led Armenian History Month initiative, but also to involve faculty and their university administrations directly," Berikyan said, "because I think it's about time that we demand the recognition and visibility that I think we deserve."

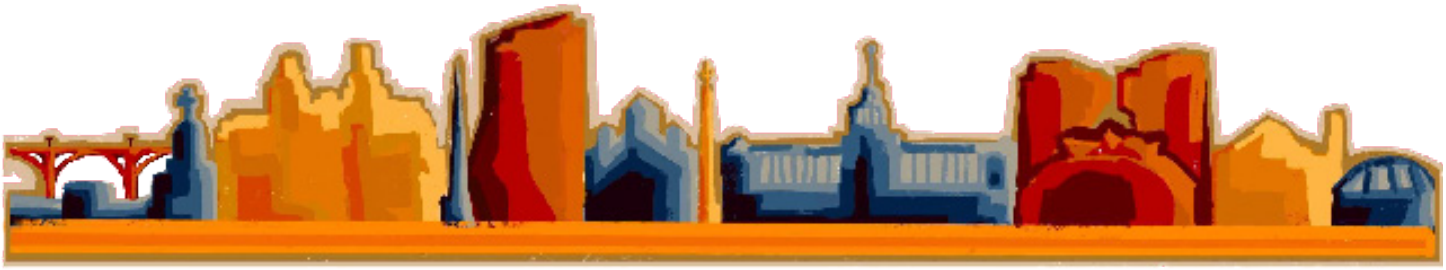
Chorbajian told me she envisions setting up a charity in partnership with the University to raise money for the broader community.

Karapetian hopes to continue offering Armenian History Month at USC and to continue engaging the community with different Armenian traditions. Hopefully, she said, in future years, it will not have the backdrop of a recent tragedy.

"We'll have Armenian History Month every [year] and I'm excited ... to offer a different menu of modes of engagement every year, so that folks who are here for a couple of years, or faculty and staff who are here every year, get to wonder what kind of an Armenian experience they're going to have this year," she said. "And I hope that won't be in response to or reflection on catastrophic developments. I hope that it will really be a celebration instead of a commemoration."

But for now, instead of a red, blue and orange flag on game days, students can see the official, student-designed USC Armenian History Month banner on screens as big as the one in front of Allyson Felix Field.

*Jennifer Nehrer was the News assignments editor in Spring 2024. She is a rising junior majoring in journalism.*



Arielle Rizal / Daily Trojan

viewpoint
The criminal court system must help in the war against gangs — page 4.

feature
Four-foot-tall penguins and giant kangaroos invade Los Angeles — page 15.

sports
The university is ready to celebrate 100 years of athletics — page 36.

daily trojan

Volume CIV, Number 64 University of Southern California Wednesday, April 20, 1988

SOUTH AFRICA

# Morals vs. money: The divestment debate

## USC still has $24 million in South Africa

By Kathleen Berry
Staff Writer

The university now has more than $24 million invested in corporations that do business in South Africa and has not significantly decreased its investments since 1985, when the university first examined its investments in that country.

Administrators say that most of these companies have either left South Africa or been re-evaluated favorably by an outside consulting firm that rates corporations there. As a result, the university will not actively divest from that country.

"We really haven't made a conscious act of divesting — it's more or less an attrition," said William Hromadka, university treasurer. "When it's some time to sell a stock after it's

(Continued on page 13)

BRUCE LE / DAILY TROJAN

As Brian Sumerwell (right) stands on, Akim Odulate, representative of the African Students Association, reads a letter directed at President James Zumberge in a protest outside Bovard Administration Building on Tuesday. Zumberge was out of his office.

## Angry ralliers 'take a stand' on apartheid

By Michael Lambert
Staff Writer

A small crowd of students rallied outside Bovard Administration Building on Tuesday, demanding that the university "take a stand against apartheid" by pulling out the more than $24

More on South Africa — page 12.

million it has invested in South Africa.

Throughout the rally, students repeated loud chants of "Zumberge Divest!" and "USC Divest!" at the request of their leader, Akim Odulate, an influential member of the African

(Continued on page 26)

## Tuition costs soar faster than inflation — officials

By Kevin Ota
Staff Writer

As tuition at private universities continues to increase each year at twice the rate of inflation, many students are now complaining that USC simply costs too much.

But university officials contend that inflation is an inaccurate measure of the cost of an education.

While inflation for 1987 was about 4 percent, university budget officials are projecting a tuition increase of 7.5 percent to 8.5 percent this fall, said John Curry, vice president of budget and planning.

The first thing students and parents must understand, Curry said, is that the "market basket" of goods and services, on which the consumer price index and inflation are based, does not include education.

"Higher education is just one little piece of the economy — it's not even represented in the consumer price index," he said. "But if it were, it shouldn't surprise anybody that education moves at a different pace than inflation. In fact, on individual piece of the CPI goes at the average."

Curry said that to understand inflation as a college or university experiences it, people need to examine a "market basket" that specifically reflects the cost of educational institutions.

"You need to look at what USC buys, and it is kind of weird compared to what an average family buys," Curry said. "About two-thirds of what we buy are the services of faculty and staff.

"We're literally building laboratories every day — we're remodeling, adding, building. . . . These are very expensive, much more expensive than the average apartment building that is represented in the CPI."

Curry said the university also buys $8 million worth of books and periodicals each year, the prices of which have been "going through the roof for years.

(Continued on page 8)

John Curry, vice president of budget and planning, says tuition must rise faster than inflation because of book costs, new buildings, financial aid demands and professor salaries.

*Commencement*

## Duke, top students will share spotlight

By Jordana Riezz
Staff Writer

This year's valedictorians, like the 5,147 other students who will walk through commencement ceremonies May 6, will not receive their diplomas until after degree checks are completed this summer. But Gov. George Deukmejian will receive one on the spot.

Deukmejian, who is this year's commencement speaker, and three others who have demonstrated commitment and excellence in their fields of expertise will receive honorary doctoral degrees.

Following his 15-minute address to the graduates, the governor will be awarded a doctor of humane letters degree. Sir Randolph Quirk, an expert in the history and usage of the English language, will receive a doctor of literature degree; Olga Taussky-Todd, a mathematician, will be granted a doctor of science degree, and composer Miklos Rozsa will receive a doctor of music degree.

Co-valedictorians Ken Bacher and Kim Valentine will each have the honor of addressing the graduates for three minutes on a topic of their choice.

The three-minute speech is the only chance for the valedictorians to be recognized by their fellow graduates, said Robert Maxson, dean for student life.

Maxson, a member of the committee that selects valedictorians, said the honor goes to those students who have demonstrated academic excellence and "balanced participation in university life." This participation can include membership in honor societies, holding a position in student government, or writing for the Daily Trojan, he said.

Although both of this year's valedictorians have grade point averages of 4.0, Maxson said that is not a requirement for receiving the honor. It's possible for the selection committee to pass over a 4.0 student in favor of a student with a slightly lower GPA but an impressive back-

(Continued on page 6)

**FROM THE ARCHIVES** – The front page of the *Daily Trojan*, April 20, 1988. (Daily Trojan Archives / USC Libraries)

SUMMER FRAME

# Hometowns

ISABELLA VILLANUEVA

With the commencement of the summer season, many USC students can now look forward to uninterrupted time for themselves, reuniting with friends and family back home, and the lack of a sleep schedule. In the same spirit as our recent spring semester's "Weekly Frame," the *Daily Trojan*'s staff photographers Zongyi Wang and Britney Zhou were tasked with capturing their hometowns in a new installment of the "Summer Frame."

From the unique perspectives of different locations, one can feel what hometowns mean to each of these photographers. Experience secondhand nostalgia and take a vulnerable look into how these photographers see their hometowns and the people within them.

Britney Zhou / Daily Trojan

Zongyi Wang / Daily Trojan

Britney Zhou / Daily Trojan

Zongyi Wang / Daily Trojan

Zongyi Wang / Daily Trojan

Zongyi Wang / Daily Trojan

Britney Zhou / Daily Trojan

# An Open Letter to 'The Baby-Sitters Club' as I Begin the Last Episode

*Knowing our time is limited, knowing we are down to our final 28 minutes, I want to say some parting words as we stand on the precipice of goodbye.*

RACHEL KOZIK

Vivienne Tran / Daily Trojan

They say nothing lasts forever. And you, a 2020-21 TV series about Connecticut middle schoolers running a successful child care enterprise, and me are no exception. Knowing our time is limited, knowing we are down to our final 28 minutes, I want to say some parting words as we stand on the precipice of goodbye.

When I began watching you at the start of this semester, I thought I was safe from any attachment. And not just because I am a 28-year-old woman, and you are a peak-pandemic Netflix show geared toward viewers who are later-end "Zoomers" or squarely Generation Alphas.

Having never read your source material as a child, I don't know why I stumbled upon you now all these years later. (When you first premiered, I was in an on-again, off-again relationship with "Emily in Paris." Suffice it to say that 2020 was a dark time.) The start doesn't matter because we are now where we were always headed: the end.

Looking back, I can't deny how naive I was. I told myself you would just be background noise to accompany my morning bowl of granola. I told myself you would just be a good way to keep up my French if I dubbed your audio en français with English subtitles. I told myself you would just be like all the other shows I had strictly casual dalliances with before. But these boundaries didn't work. I fell for you. I fell hard.

Without meaning to, I crossed that line, dividing viewers from fleeting to engaged. An episode turned into a season. A morning-multitasking watch turned into a focused Friday night watch. Soon thereafter, the emotions got involved and there was no turning back.

I identified with Kristy (and not just because she's the subtly queer one) because she was bossy and I channeled her (and her visor) when I needed to be assertive. I participated in conversations (with myself) explaining why I felt frustrated with Dawn's activism throughout the show, appreciating the nuanced and elusive distinction between necessary and performative social action. I searched for terracotta jumpsuits to buy like the one Claudia wore before a cooler head (read: insecurities) prevailed before purchase. I was upset with (but also slightly afraid of) those teenage girls who stole the BSC's idea with their meretricious copycat "The Baby-Sitter's Agency." And, perhaps most telling, I just used "BSC" in a sentence without any intended irony.

Looking back, I am not proud of how I treated you. Like when a classmate or teaching assistant would see you on a tab, and I would act like I didn't know how you got there. Like how — with the exception of my friend from Smith College who loved your books growing up and actually met Ann M. Martin in real life — I would make up something age-appropriate and brooding when people asked if I was watching anything good lately. Like when I shared songs with my friends from your soundtrack (which were very well-received, by the way,) and passed them off as my own cool, sad girl finds.

We both knew our time would run out eventually. (I looked it up around episode three, and you got canceled in 2022 despite "universal acclaim.") We both knew there were other shows I also watched on the side. But, for two seasons totaling 18 episodes, we navigated fictional, impeccably dressed multi-character coming-of-age milestones. I will miss your company, but I must leave you behind in Stoneybrook.

But, before I do, I need to say something I've never told another show before: You were worth it. You were worth the plans I said no to (read: none) to watch you. You were worth whatever French oral comprehension I didn't learn when I switched back to English audio so I could hear the characters in their original voices. And, believe me when I tell you this, you were worth the effects already experienced on Netflix's algorithm for future suggestions "Because You Watched 'The Baby-Sitter's Club.'"

Because you weren't just any other show. Because your presence will be felt after the credits roll. Because when I run out of episodes, I will be left with an aspiration I will never outgrow: to forge friendships and find friends like those entrepreneur adolescents did, especially ones that know where to buy terracotta jumpsuits.

Goodbye and thank you for everything, BSC. And with that, I hit play on "Kristy and the Baby Parade."

*Rachel Kozik was a staff writer at the* Daily Trojan Magazine *in Spring 2024. She is a graduate student studying applied data science.*

DT
mag
EST. 2023